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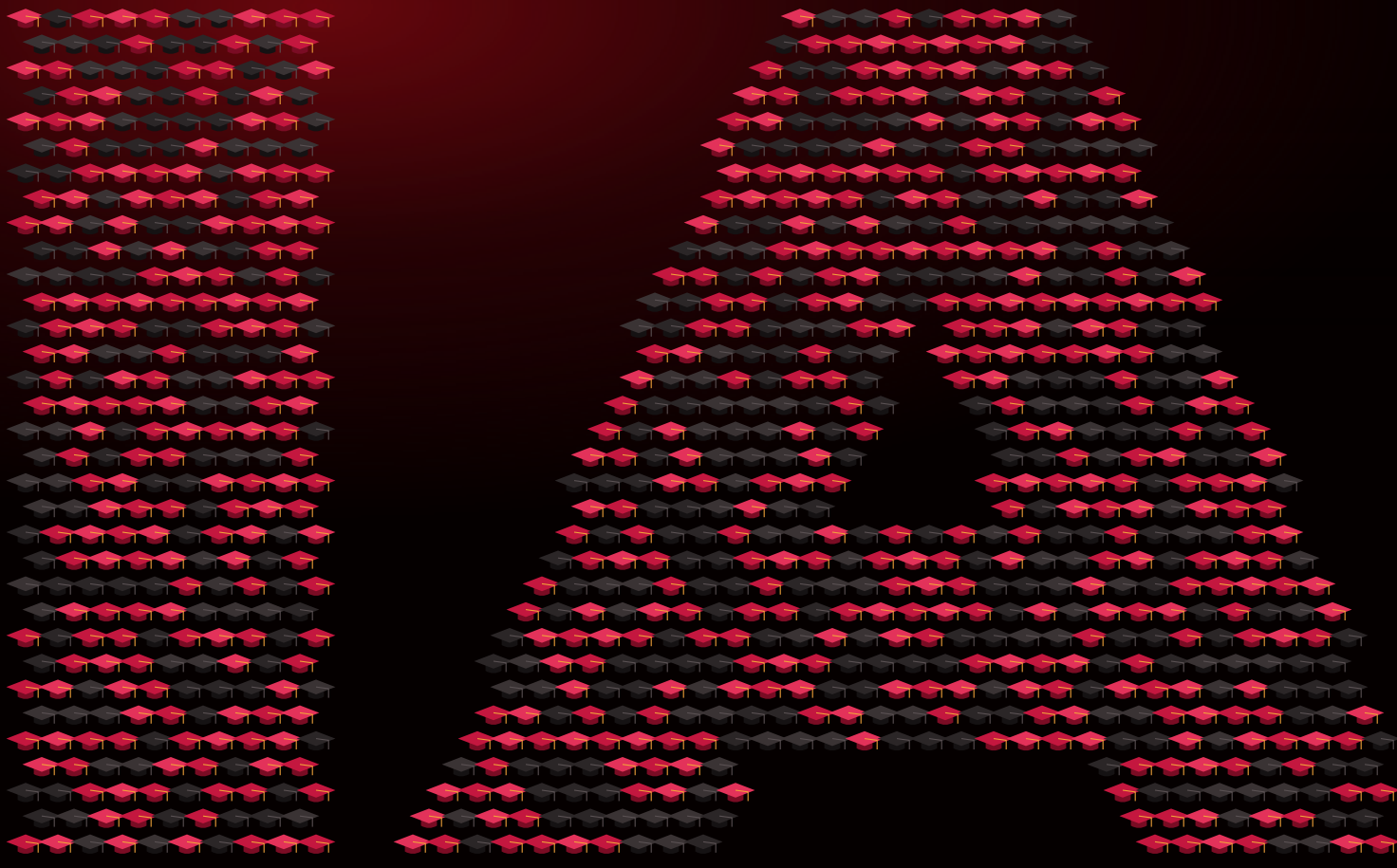
HAI Stanford University Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence

NOVEMBER 2026

The 2026 Iowa Talent Profile

Emerson Johnston
Amy Zegart

The bright caps, **55 in every 100**, mark the international share of Iowa's STEM master's degrees.



The 2026 Iowa Talent Profile

By Emerson Johnston and Amy Zegart

NOVEMBER 2026

A publication jointly produced by the Hoover Institution and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence at Stanford University.

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Data come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), the Department of Homeland Security's SEVIS by the Numbers, the National Assessment of Educational Progress, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates and Survey of Earned Doctorates, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and USPTO patent data via PatentsView, processed in Python; every figure and table is generated from those sources, and each one names its source.

About This Profile

This profile is a companion to *The 2026 US Talent Report: Benchmarking America's STEM Pipeline Amid the Great Talent Competition*. It applies the report's measures to Iowa: the students the state develops at home, those it draws from abroad, and how both compare with the nation and with the states closest to it in size.

Degrees, enrollment, prices, outcomes and faculty come from IPEDS, the federal census of U.S. colleges and universities, harmonized across 1980–2025. Countries of citizenship come from SEVIS by the Numbers, the Department of Homeland Security's monthly count of active F-1 and M-1 students. Each figure names its source. Peer states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

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How to Cite this Profile

Emerson V. Johnston and Amy Zegart, “The 2026 Iowa Talent Profile,” Technology Policy Accelerator, Hoover Institution, and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence, Stanford University, Stanford, CA, November 2026.

Public Data and Tools

The data behind every chart come from federal sources: the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), published by the National Center for Education Statistics, as the backbone, together with NAEP, NSF's surveys of graduate students, doctorates and research funding, USAspending.gov, DHS and ICE SEVIS data, the Department of Labor, USCIS, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes, and USPTO PatentsView. Each figure names its source, and the Sources page lists all of them. An interactive version of this profile accompanies the report.

To share any charts and figures, proper attribution is required. This profile is licensed under Attribution-NoDerivatives 4.0 International (CC BY-ND 4.0). Please cite as: The 2026 Iowa Talent Profile.

AT A GLANCE

What Iowa's numbers say

1. **International students earn 55% of Iowa's STEM master's degrees,** 2.9 points above the U.S. (52%) in 2025, ranking 12th of 51 on dependence. The share is 46% for STEM research doctorates (U.S. 43%) and 6.1% for STEM bachelor's (U.S. 6.6%).
2. **Iowa awarded 556 STEM master's degrees to international students in 2025,** 0.5% of the U.S. total and 31st of 51 among states. Since 2015 the count changed +44%, against 2.2× nationally.
3. **The heaviest dependence is in computer & info sciences,** where international students earned 81% of master's degrees (462 degrees; U.S. 65%). One STEM field with at least 50 master's graduates is majority-international.
4. **Among states of similar size,** Iowa ranks 2nd of 5 on the international share of STEM master's: Iowa 55%, Oregon 37%, Oklahoma 40%, Kansas 50%, Connecticut 68%.
5. **66% of Iowa's first-time students in fall 2024 were state residents** and 2.6% came from abroad. More students arrived from other states (10.1K) than residents left (4.08K), a net gain of 5.98K; the top destination for those leaving was South Dakota.

55%

of the STEM master's degrees Iowa awards go to international students (U.S. 52%).

SCORECARD

Nine numbers against the nation

207K #29
Students enrolled, 2024
U.S. **19.7M** · −25% since 2015

556 #31
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · +44% since 2015

55% #12
International share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · +17.2 pp since 2015

15% #23
International share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · +3.6 pp since 2015

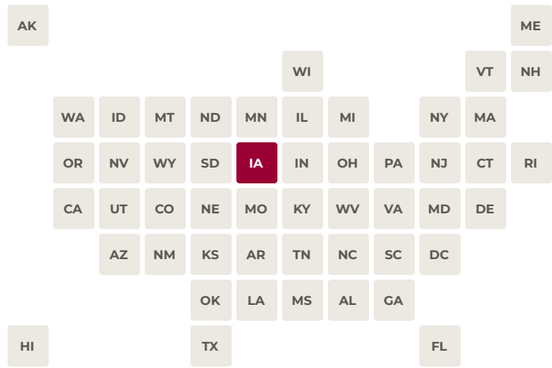
22% #28
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · +5.1 pp since 2015

69% #9
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · +1.9 pp since 2015

$9.86K #34
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · −4.4% since 2015

66% #35
First-time students from in state, 2024
+4.9 pp since 2016

$88.1K #36
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · −12% since 2016



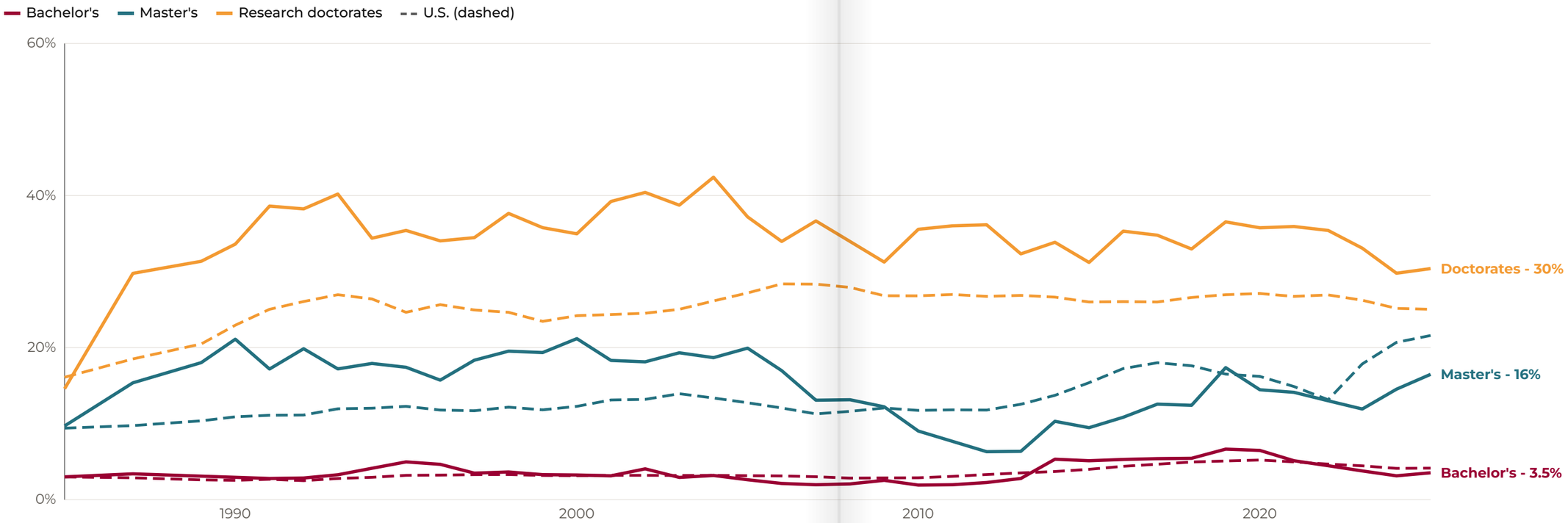
Badges give Iowa's rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Changes are since 2015.

SECTION 1

International Dependence

Iowa ranks 12th of 51 on the international share of STEM master's, at 55% in 2025 against 52% for the U.S.

Figure 1 What Share of Iowa's Degrees Go to International Students?



International share of degrees awarded, all fields; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions, 1985–2025.

International students make up 15% of Iowa's graduate enrollment and 2.7% of its undergraduates. Dependence climbs with each degree: 3.5% of bachelor's, 16% of master's and 30% of research doctorates go to international students.

In STEM the shares are higher still: 6.1% of STEM bachelor's, 55% of STEM master's and 46% of STEM doctorates. The state awards 0.5% of all U.S. international STEM master's, 31st of 51.

15%

Int. share of grad students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **23rd** of 51 · +3.6 pp since 2015

16%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

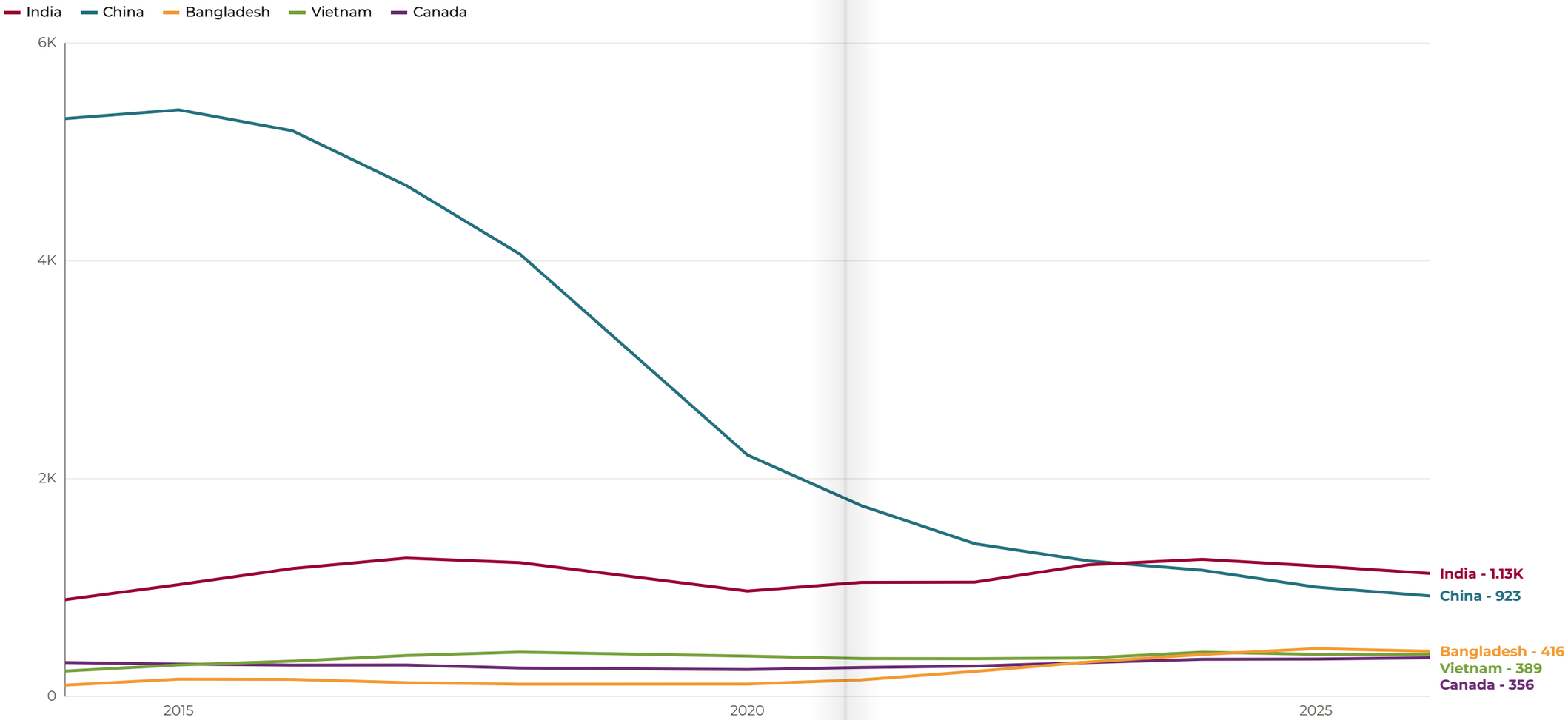
U.S. **22%** · **24th** of 51 · +7.0 pp since 2015

55%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **12th** of 51 · +17.2 pp since 2015

Figure 2 Where Do Iowa's International Students Come From?



Active F-1 and M-1 students by country of citizenship, the five largest in October 2026; one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November), October 2014–October 2026. All education levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

In October 2026, Iowa had 9.02K active international students in SEVIS, 31st of 51. India accounted for 13% of them and China for 10%, against 27% and 18% nationally.

Students came from 173 countries, but the two largest supplied 23%. The state's total is down 32% since 2015, when it stood at 13.3K.

9.02K
Active international students, October 2026
31st of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

13%
From India
U.S. **27%**

53%
In STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

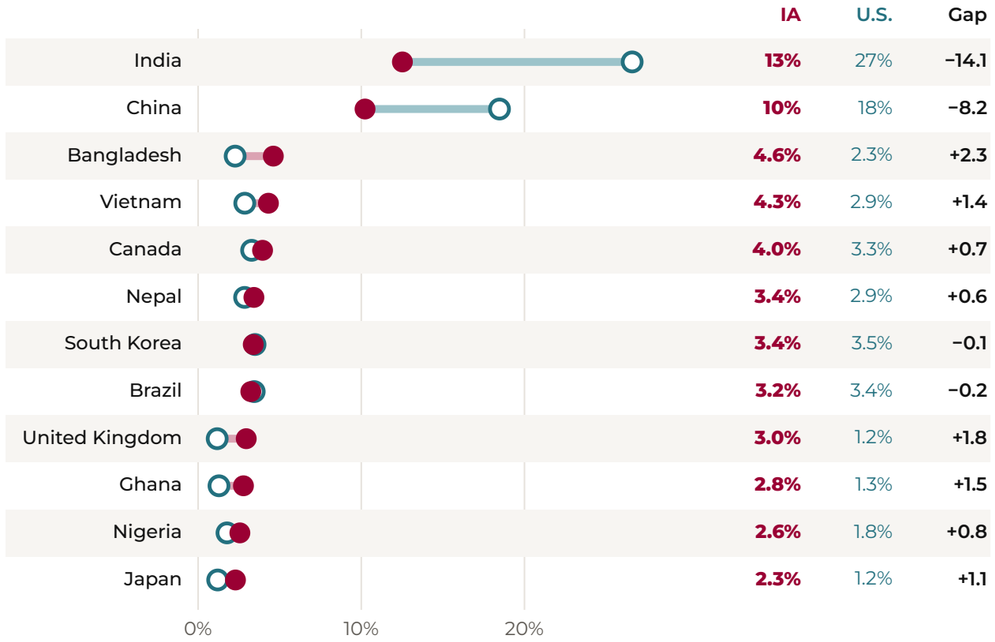
How Does Iowa's Mix of Countries Compare With the Nation's?

In October 2026, Iowa had **9.02K** active F-1 and M-1 students, 31st among the 50 states and DC and **0.8%** of the U.S. total. They came from 173 countries.

India supplied **13%** of them, against 27% nationally, and China **10%**, against 18%. Bangladesh (4.6%), Vietnam (4.3%), and Canada (4.0%) followed.

Together the two largest countries supplied **23%** of the state's international students (U.S. 45%), 43rd among the states, against 48% in 2015.

Figure 3 Is Iowa's Mix of Countries Like the Nation's?



Share of active F-1 and M-1 students, all levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

9.02K
Active international students, October 2026
31st of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

13%
From India
U.S. **27%**

10%
From China
U.S. **18%**

173
Countries represented
U.S. **219**

The state's count is down 6.8% from 2025 and down 32% since 2015, when it stood at 13.3K. Its share of all U.S. international students is down 0.4 points since 2015, to **0.8%**.

Since 2015, the number of students from India went from 1.03K to 1.13K, China's from 5.39K to 923, and Bangladesh's from 160 to 416.

Over the same years, the number from Vietnam went from 291 to 389 and Canada's from 298 to 356. The table gives each country's count for the first, previous and latest years.

Table 1 International Students in Iowa, 2015–2026

	2015	2025	2026	Change since 2015	U.S. 2026	Rank
ALL INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS						
Active F-1 and M-1 students	13.3K	9.68K	**9.02K**	−32%	1.19M	31st
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	1.1%	0.8%	**0.8%**	−0.4 pp	–	31st
Countries of citizenship represented	170	175	**173**	+1.8%	219	17th
Share from the two largest countries of origin	48%	23%	**23%**	−25.4 pp	45%	43rd
LARGEST COUNTRIES OF CITIZENSHIP (STUDENTS)					**U.S. SHARE**	**STATE SHARE**
India	1.03K	1.2K	**1.13K**	+9.9%	27%	13%
China	5.39K	1K	**923**	−83%	18%	10%
Bangladesh	160	440	**416**	+160%	2.3%	4.6%
Vietnam	291	387	**389**	+34%	2.9%	4.3%
Canada	298	344	**356**	+19%	3.3%	4.0%

Active F-1 and M-1 students, one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November; 2019 has none; the latest year is October 2026). Rank among the 50 states and DC. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

Figure 4

Which Countries Supply Iowa's International STEM Students?

4.78K of Iowa's international students were in STEM fields in October 2026, **53%** of the total against 63% nationally, down 21% since 2015.

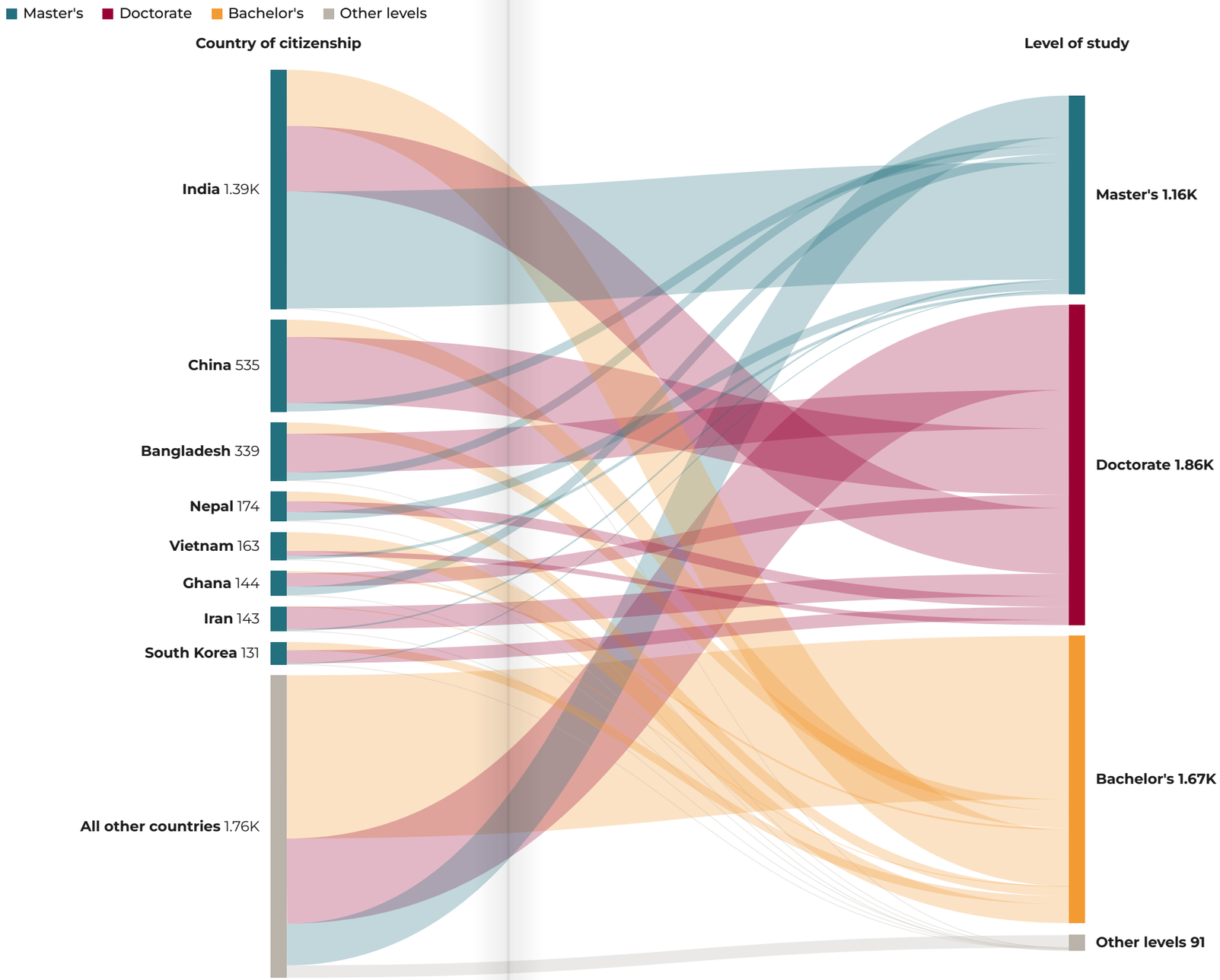
Doctoral students were the largest group, **1.86K**. China supplied 21% of them and India 20%.

STEM doctoral students went from 1.55K in 2015 to **1.86K**, and STEM master's students from 1.59K to 1.16K.

4.78K
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students, 2026
U.S. **749K** · **28th** of 51 · −21% since 2015

53%
Share in STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

1.16K
Active STEM master's students, 2026
U.S. **393K** · **36th** of 51 · −27% since 2015



Active F-1 and M-1 students in STEM fields by country of citizenship and level of study, October 2026; the eight largest countries are shown. DHS does not draw its STEM pages on the same basis as its all-student pages, so the STEM count here exceeds the all-level count for India (1.39K against 1.13K). Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

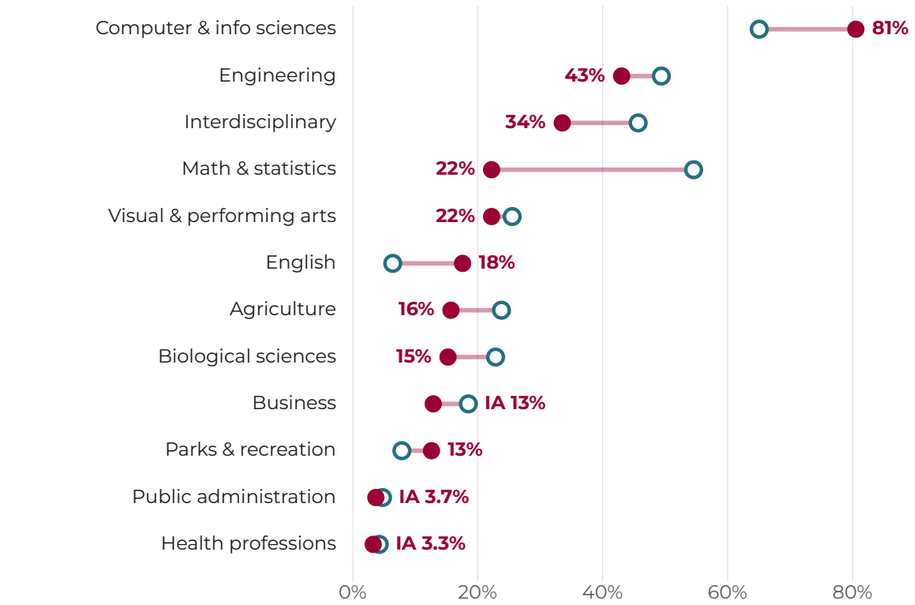
SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How International Are Iowa's Master's Fields?

Each row is a master's field with at least 30 graduates in Iowa in 2025, ranked by the share of degrees earned by international students (U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas). The filled dot is the state's share; the open dot is the national share for the same field.

Highest international shares. International students earned the largest shares of master's degrees in computer & info sciences (81%, against 65% for the U.S.), engineering (43%, against 49% for the U.S.), and interdisciplinary (34%, against 46% for the U.S.).

Figure 5 Which Master's Fields Depend Most on International Students?



International share of master's degrees by field, 2025; fields with 30+ graduates. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

16%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **24th** of 51

55%
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **12th** of 51

81%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **11th** of 47

The table gives the international share of degrees in each STEM field at three levels: Iowa first, the United States after the slash. The master's column is highlighted. A dash means the state awarded no degrees in the field at that level.

Highest international share among STEM master's fields. International students earned 81% of the master's degrees in computer & info sciences, against 65% for the U.S.

Fields with an international majority. International students earned more than half of the master's degrees in one STEM field.

Table 2 How International Is Each STEM Field?

Field	Bachelor's	Master's	Doctorates
Computer & info sciences	14% / 8.6%	**81% / 65%**	63% / 56%
Engineering	4.8% / 7.2%	**43% / 49%**	62% / 55%
Engineering technology	2.1% / 4.5%	**– / 54%**	– / 42%
Math & statistics	8.1% / 17%	**22% / 55%**	52% / 53%
Physical sciences	8.0% / 6.0%	**23% / 33%**	43% / 38%
Biological sciences	4.3% / 3.4%	**15% / 23%**	27% / 23%
Natural resources	0.8% / 2.0%	**– / 17%**	– / 27%
Architecture	3.1% / 7.3%	**62% / 29%**	– / 55%

International share in Iowa / U.S., 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

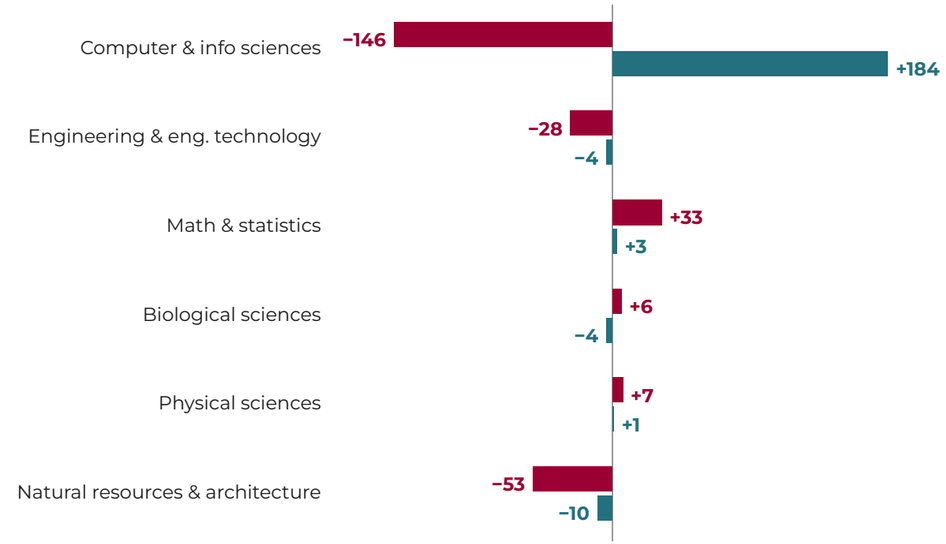
SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How Has Iowa's STEM Master's Output Grown?

Each pair of bars is the change in the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Iowa between 2015 and 2025 in one field: to domestic students (U.S. citizens and permanent residents) and to international students. Bars to the left of the axis are declines.

STEM master's degrees. The state awarded 1.01K in 2025 and 1.02K in 2015, a change of +170 for international students and −181 for domestic students.

Figure 6 Where Did the STEM Master's Growth Come From?



Change in STEM master's degrees by field, 2015–2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

556
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · **31st** of 51

17%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **36th** of 51

0.5%
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025
31st of 51

2.7
STEM master's per STEM research doctorate, 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **48th** of 51

The table gives the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Iowa in each field in 2015 and 2025, the change between the two years, the number awarded to international students in 2025, and international students' share of the field's degrees in each year.

STEM share of master's degrees. The share was 17% in 2025, against 23% for the U.S., 36th among the states, down 1.2 points from 18% in 2024 and up 4.4 points since 2015, when it was 12%.

Table 3 How Many STEM Master's Degrees Does Each Field Award?

Field	2015	2025	Change	International 2025	Int. share 2015	Int. share 2025
Computer & info sciences	424	**462**	+9.0%	372	44%	81%
Engineering & eng. technology	300	**268**	−11%	118	41%	44%
Math & statistics	63	**99**	+57%	22	30%	22%
Biological sciences	103	**105**	+1.9%	16	19%	15%
Physical sciences	27	**35**	–	8	–	23%
Natural resources & architecture	105	**42**	−60%	20	29%	48%

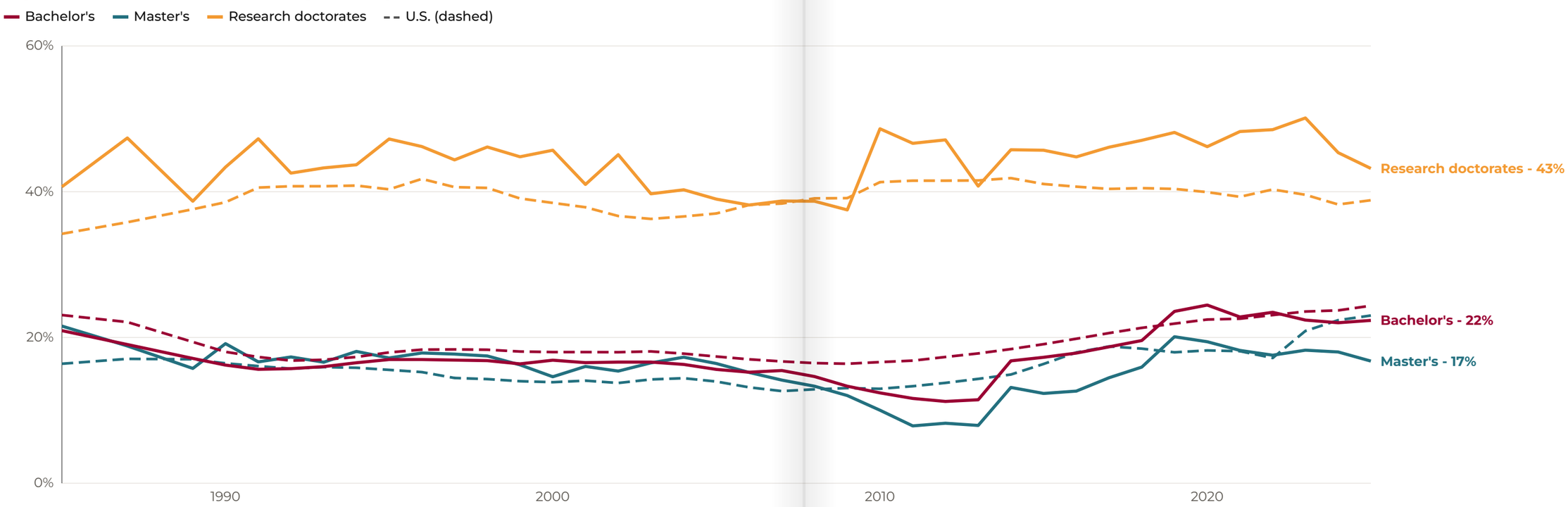
STEM master's degrees awarded in Iowa, all students and international students, 2015 and 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

SECTION 2

STEM Degrees

Iowa ranks 36th of 51 on the STEM share of master's, at 17% in 2025 against 23% for the U.S.

Figure 7 How Much of Iowa's Degree Output Is STEM?



STEM share of degrees by level; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

STEM fields account for 22% of Iowa's bachelor's degrees, 17% of its master's and 43% of its research doctorates (U.S. 24%, 23% and 39%).

The STEM share of master's degrees is up 4.4 points since 2015, and the state ranks 36th of 51 on it. On the STEM share of bachelor's degrees it ranks 28th of 51.

22%

STEM share of bachelor's, 2025

U.S. **24%** · **28th** of 51 · +5.1 pp since 2015

17%

STEM share of master's, 2025

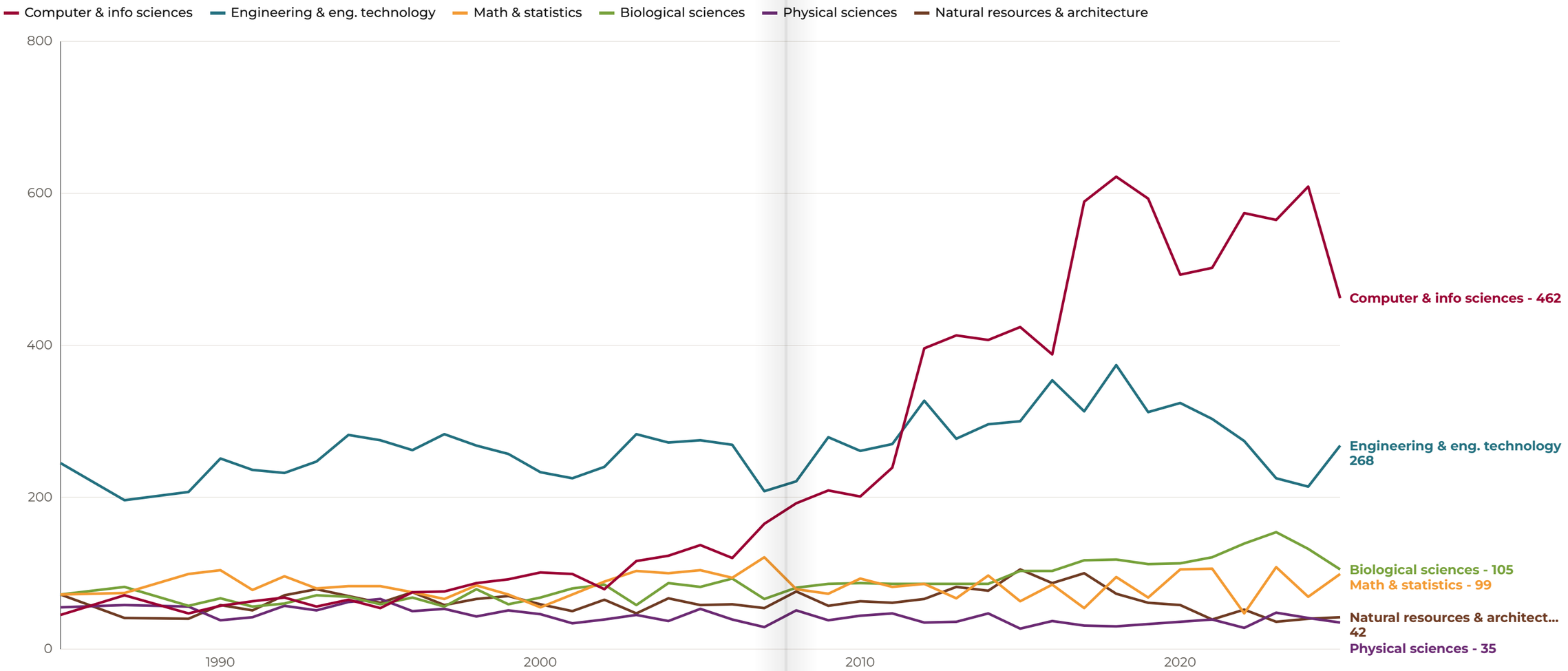
U.S. **23%** · **36th** of 51 · +4.4 pp since 2015

43%

STEM share of research doctorates, 2025

U.S. **39%** · **23rd** of 51 · −2.5 pp since 2015

Figure 8 Which STEM Fields Produce Iowa's Master's Degrees?



STEM master's degrees by field, all students. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Computer & info sciences produced the most STEM master's degrees in 2025, 462, followed by engineering & eng. technology (268) and biological sciences (105). Master's degrees in computer & info sciences are up 9% since 2015.

International students earned 556 of the state's STEM master's degrees in 2025, 0.5% of the national total (31st of 51).

556

International STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **117K** · **31st** of 51 · +44% since 2015

0.5%

Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025

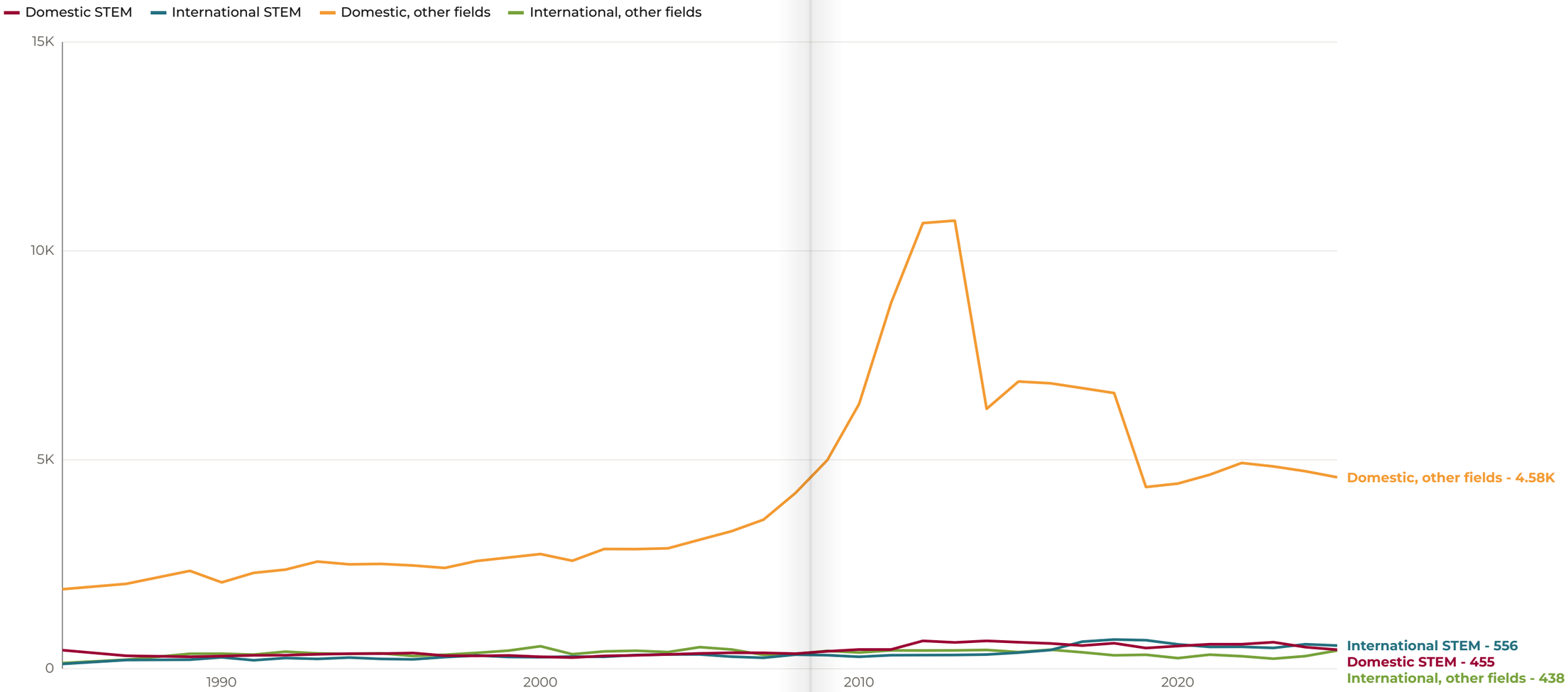
31st of 51 · −0.2 pp since 2015

81%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

U.S. **65%** · **11th** of 47 · +36.2 pp since 2015

Figure 9 Who Earns Iowa's Master's Degrees?



Master's degrees by student residency and field group. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Between 2015 and 2025, 170 more STEM master's degrees went to international students and −181 more to domestic students.

International students earn 55% of Iowa's STEM master's but 8.7% of master's in other fields (U.S. 52% and 12%).

16%

Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **24th** of 51 · +7.0 pp since 2015

55%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **12th** of 51 · +17.2 pp since 2015

2.7

STEM master's per STEM research doctorate (IPEDS), 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **48th** of 51 · −0.1 since 2015

SECTION 3

Where Students Come From

Iowa ranks 10th of 51 on net student migration, at +23 in 2024.

Figure 10 First-Time Students by Home and Destination, Fall 2024



Home of first-time degree-seeking undergraduates (left) and the state of the institution entered (right); the five largest sources and destinations (more when states tie at the printed figure), the rest grouped; ties are ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

22.3K residents stayed in Iowa for college in fall 2024; 10.1K students arrived from other states and 877 from abroad, while 4.08K residents left.

Each band runs from a student's home on the left to the state where they enrolled on the right. 66% of the state's first-time students are residents.

66%

First-time students from in state, 2024

35th of 51 · +4.9 pp since 2016

2.6%

First-time students from abroad, 2024

U.S. **3.1%** · **25th** of 51 · −1.0 pp since 2016

+23

Net migration per 100 residents, 2024

10th of 51 · −12.1 since 2016

Figure 11 How Have the Flows Changed?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by flow; even years before 2001. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Since 2015, the number of residents staying in state for college is down 5%, arrivals from other states are down 21%, and residents leaving are up 19%.

Net migration was +23 per 100 resident first-time students (10th of 51). The top destination for residents who left was South Dakota (527).

Figure 12

Where Do Iowa's Newcomers Come From?

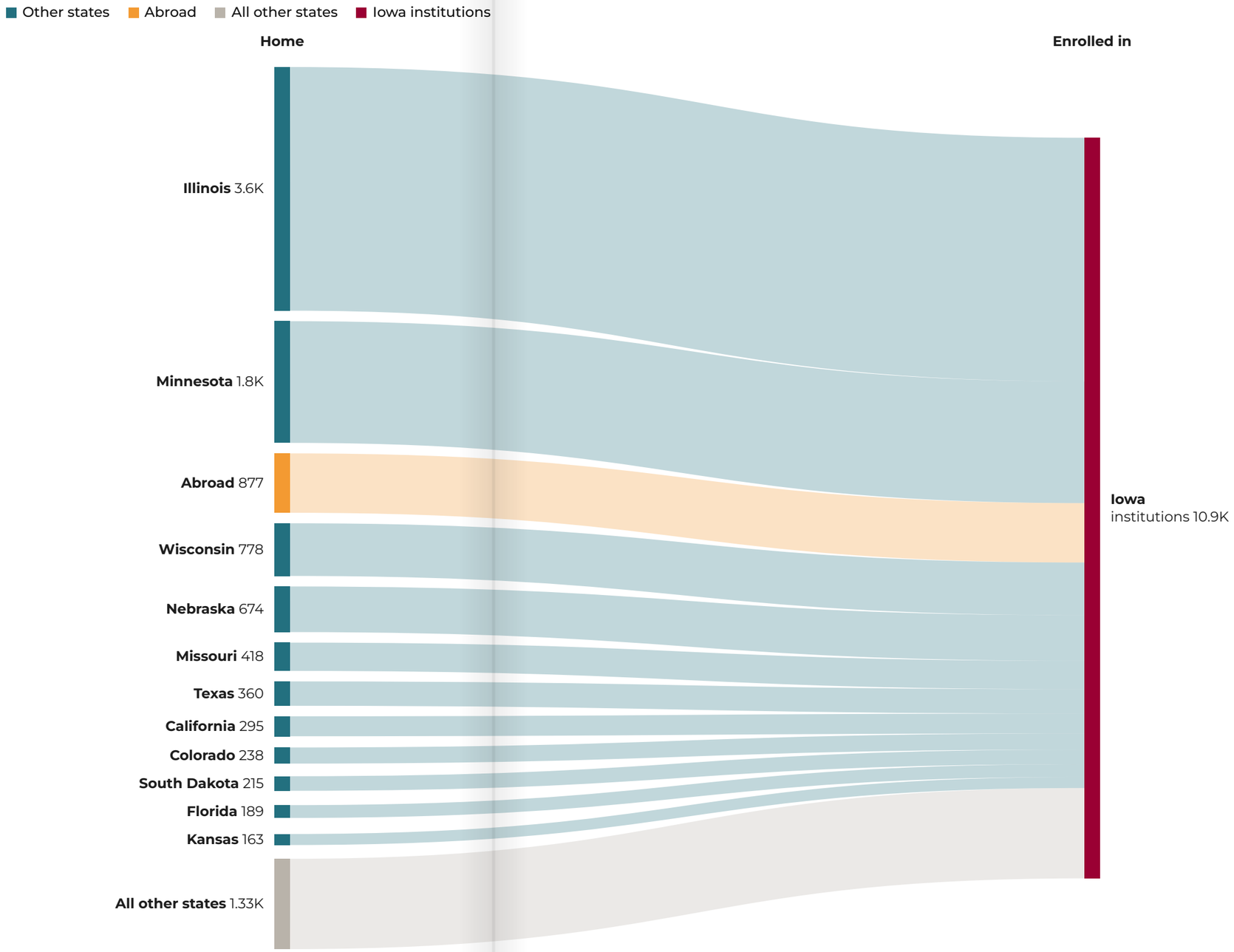
The bands show where first-time degree-seeking undergraduates who enrolled at Iowa's institutions in fall 2024 but did not live in the state came from: the 12 largest home states and students from abroad, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Home is the state where the student lived when admitted.

Students arriving from other states. The number was 10.1K in fall 2024, down 4.5% from 10.5K in fall 2022 and down 21% since fall 2016, when it was 12.8K.

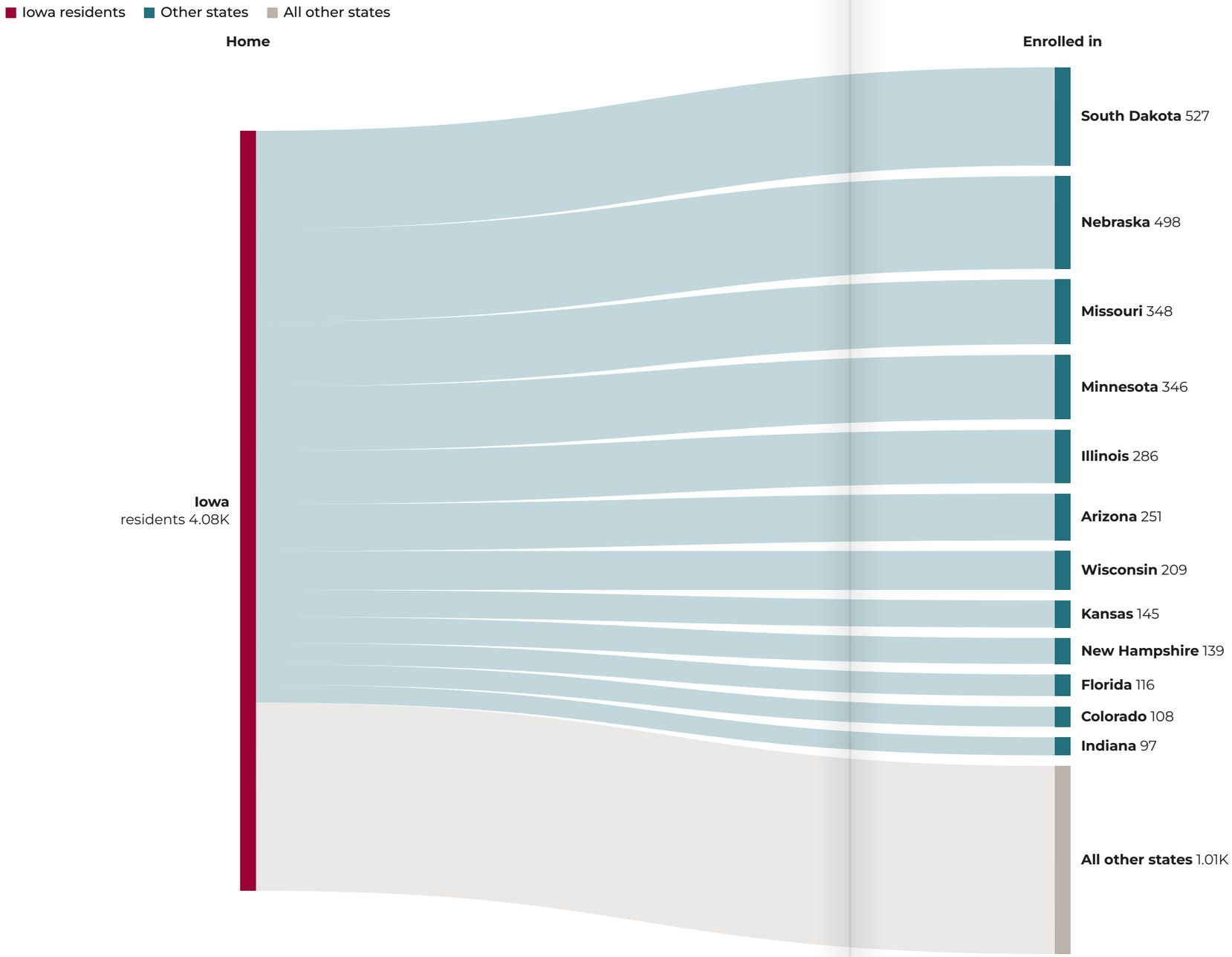
10.9K
First-time students from other states and abroad, fall 2024
Abroad **877**

2.6%
First-time students from abroad, 2024
U.S. **3.1%** · **25th** of 51 · −1.0 pp since 2016

66%
First-time students from in state, 2024
35th of 51 · +4.9 pp since 2016



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows (more when states tie at the printed figure), ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows (more when states tie at the printed figure), ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Figure 13

Where Do Iowa's Residents Go When They Leave?

The bands show where Iowa residents who left the state to start college in fall 2024 enrolled: the 12 largest destination states, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Residents who enrolled in the state are not shown.

Residents leaving for other states. The number was 4.08K in fall 2024, up 5.0% from 3.88K in fall 2022 and up 19% since fall 2016, when it was 3.44K.

4.08K
Residents who started college in another state, fall 2024
Arrived from other states **10.1K** · **10.9K** with abroad

+23
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024
10th of 51 · −12.1 since 2016

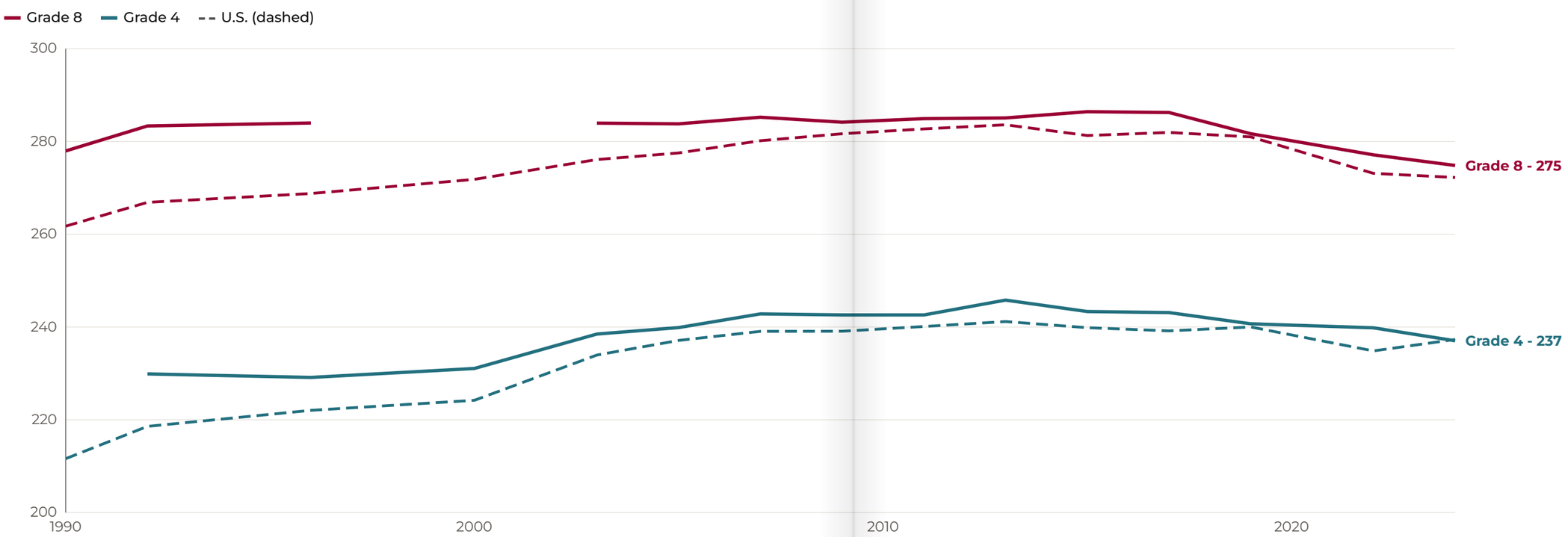
527
Went to South Dakota
The largest destination

SECTION 4

K-12 Preparation

Iowa ranks 10th of 51 on the average grade 8 reading score, at 261 in 2024 against 257 for the U.S.

Figure 14 How Well Prepared in Mathematics Are Iowa's Students?



Average NAEP mathematics score, public schools, 0–500 scale; state solid, U.S. public schools dashed. Data from NCES, National Assessment of Educational Progress.

The talent pipeline starts in school. Iowa's eighth graders averaged 275 in mathematics on the 2024 NAEP, against 272 for U.S. public schools, 23rd of 51 among the states. 27% scored at or above the Proficient level (U.S. 27%). Differences of a point or two are often within the margin of error.

275

Grade 8 math score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **272** · **23rd** of 51 · −11.6 since 2015

27%

Grade 8 math, at or above Proficient, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **24th** of 51 · −10.1 pp since 2015

261

Grade 8 reading score (NAEP), 2024

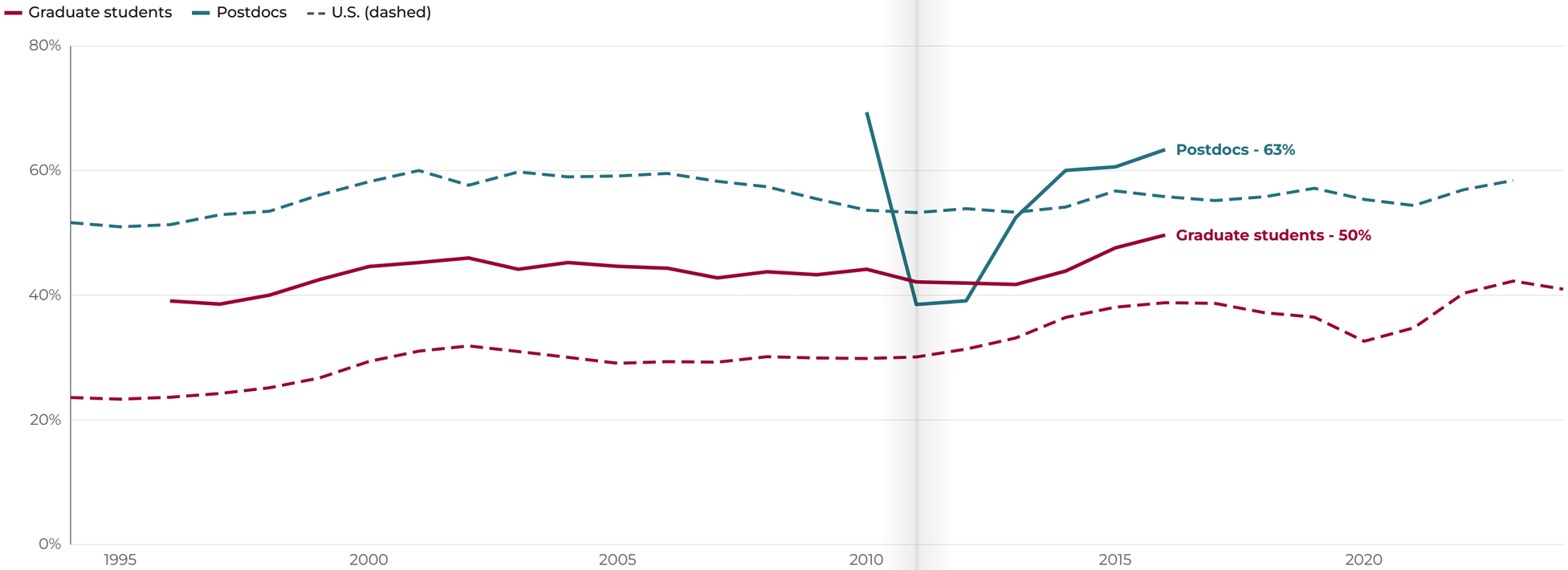
U.S. **257** · **10th** of 51 · −7.5 since 2015

SECTION 5

Graduate Research

Iowa ranks 4th of 51 on the temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students, at 50% in 2016 against 39% for the U.S.

Figure 15 How Many of Iowa's Science and Engineering Graduate Students Hold Temporary Visas?



Temporary-visa share of science and engineering graduate students and postdoctoral appointees, by the institution's state; state solid, U.S. dashed. NSF stopped publishing state tables after 2016. Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates.

In 2016, the last year NSF published state tables, 50% of Iowa's science and engineering graduate students held temporary visas (U.S. 39%; 4th of 51).

Among postdoctoral researchers, the share was 63% (U.S. 56%). Postdocs are the stage of research training most dependent on international talent, and IPEDS does not count them.

The state's institutions awarded 687 research doctorates in 2025, 1.2% of the U.S. total (Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Earned Doctorates; NSF publishes doctorates by citizenship only for the nation).

50%
S&E grad students on temporary visas, 2016
U.S. **39%** · **4th** of 51 · +2.1 pp since 2015

63%
S&E postdocs on temporary visas, 2016
U.S. **56%** · **8th** of 51 · +2.8 pp since 2015

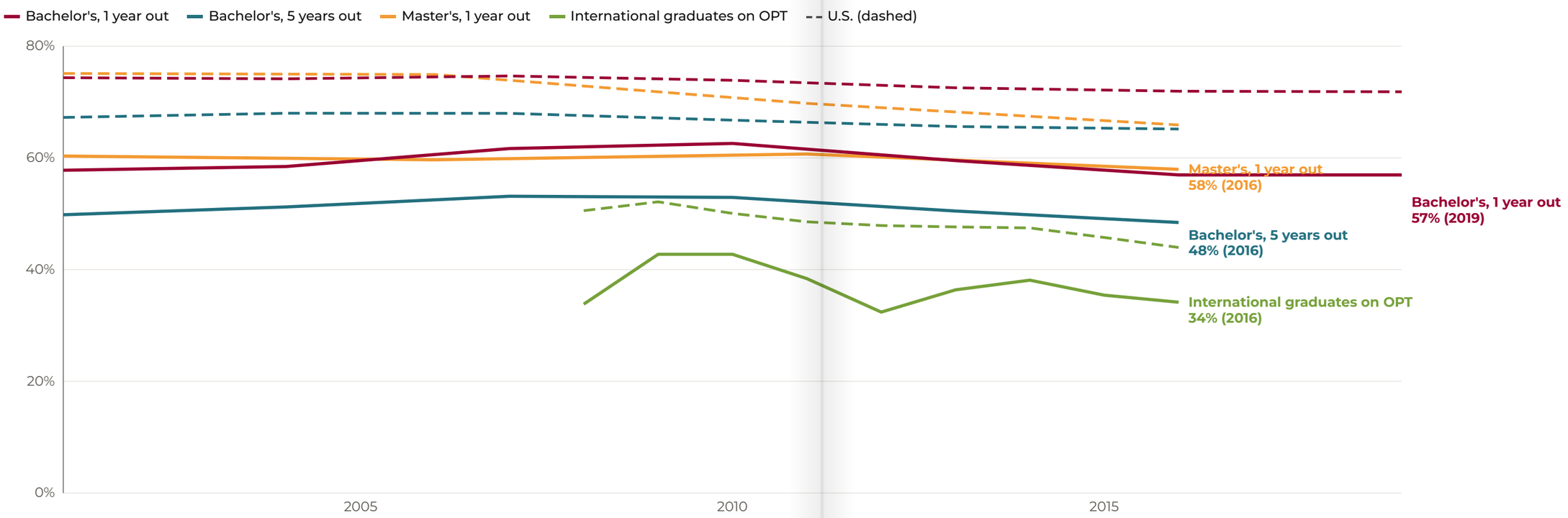
687
Research doctorates awarded (NSF SED), 2025
U.S. **59K** · **25th** of 51 · +0.1% since 2015

SECTION 6

Do Graduates Stay?

Iowa ranks 47th of 51 on net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents, at −6.4 in 2025.

Figure 16 How Many of Iowa's Graduates Go On to Work in the State?



Share of employed graduates working in the state of their institution, by graduating cohort (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes; participating institutions only); international graduates' OPT jobs in the state where they studied (Data from ICE, SEVIS FOIA releases; shares only, the file is truncated). State solid, U.S. or participating states dashed.

Of Iowa's bachelor's graduates who were working a year after graduating, 57% worked in the state (participating states 72%). Five years out the share was 48%.

Among international graduates on Optional Practical Training in 2016, 34% worked in the state where they studied (U.S. 44%). That is the last year the released records cover, before most of the growth in international STEM master's degrees since 2015. Through migration between states, the state lost 6.4 bachelor's-plus adults per 1,000 such residents in 2025 (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey).

57%

Bachelor's grads working in-state, 1 year out, 2019

U.S. **72%** · **24th** of 33 · 0.0 pp since 2016

34%

OPT graduates working in the state, 2016

U.S. **44%** · **27th** of 51 · −1.3 pp since 2015

−6.4

Net migration, bachelor's-plus, per 1,000, 2025

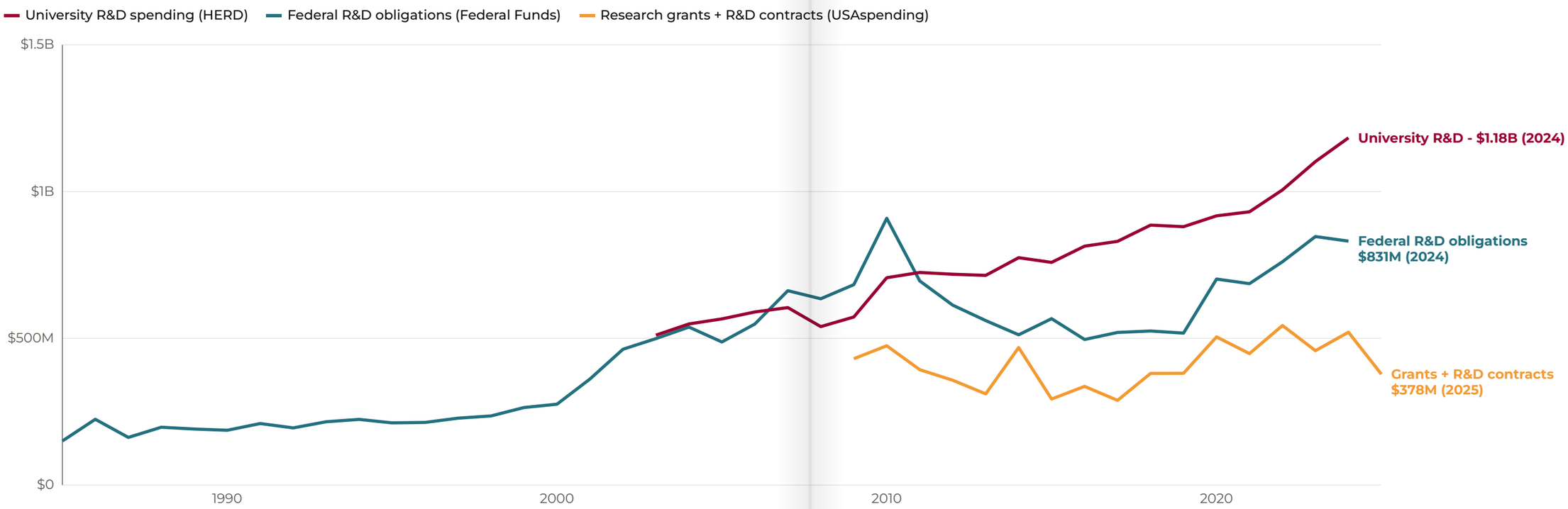
47th of 51 · +1.2 since 2015

SECTION 7

Research Funding

Iowa ranks 38th of 51 on the federally funded share of university R&D, at 47% in 2024 against 55% for the U.S.

Figure 17 How Much Research Money Flows Into Iowa?



Nominal dollars (not adjusted for inflation), fiscal years; a line ending before the others is labeled with its last year. University R&D: Data from NSF NCSES, Higher Education Research and Development Survey (FY2003-09 predecessor survey). Federal R&D obligations by state of performance: Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Federal Funds for R&D (coverage widens in FY2021). Grants from NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science plus R&D contracts: Data from USAspending.gov.

Iowa's universities spent $1.18B on research and development in FY2024, 27th of 51 among the states; 47% of it was federally funded (U.S. 55%).

Federal agencies obligated $831M for R&D performed in the state in FY2024. Research funding drives demand for graduate students and postdocs, the stage of training most dependent on international talent.

$1.18B

University R&D spending, 2024

U.S. **$118B** · **27th** of 51 · +56% since 2015

47%

Federal share of university R&D, 2024

U.S. **55%** · **38th** of 51 · +2.0 pp since 2015

$831M

Federal R&D obligations, 2024

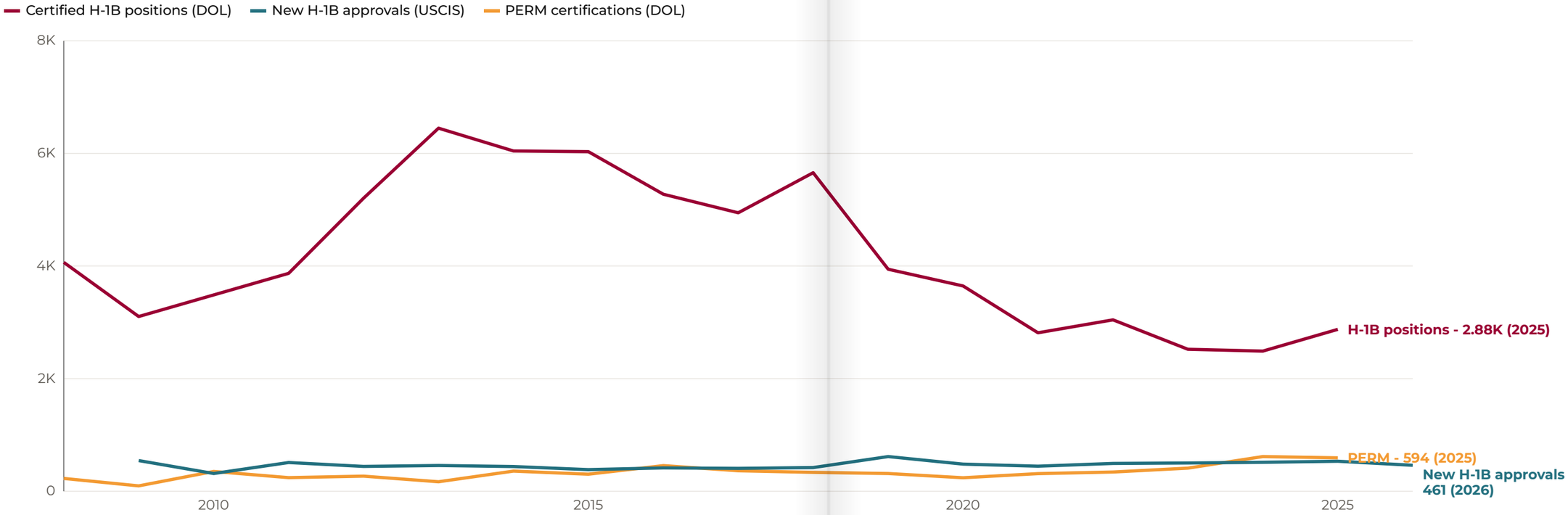
U.S. **$193B** · **31st** of 51 · +47% since 2015

SECTION 8

H-1B Jobs and Green Cards

Iowa ranks 43rd of 51 on the share of PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas, at 4.7% in 2024 against 8.7% for the U.S.

Figure 18 How Many Skilled-Visa Jobs and Green-Card Certifications Does Iowa Generate?



Certified H-1B positions on labor condition applications by worksite and certified PERM green-card applications, by fiscal year (Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification); new H-1B petition approvals by the employer's address (Data from USCIS, H-1B Employer Data Hub).

Employers were certified for 2.88K H-1B positions at Iowa worksites in FY2025, 31st of 51 among the states. A labor condition application comes before the petition and covers renewals and job changes as well as new hires, by the worksite's state, so it runs well above approvals. USCIS approved 461 new H-1B petitions in FY2026 and 999 continuing ones, counted by the employer's address.

DOL certified 594 PERM applications, the employer's step toward an employment-based green card, for jobs in the state in FY2025. In FY2024, 4.7% were for workers still on F-1 student visas (U.S. 8.7%): the most direct link from classroom to permanent residence.

2.88K

Certified H-1B positions (worksite), 2025

U.S. **914K** · **31st** of 51 · −52% since 2015

594

PERM green-card certifications, 2025

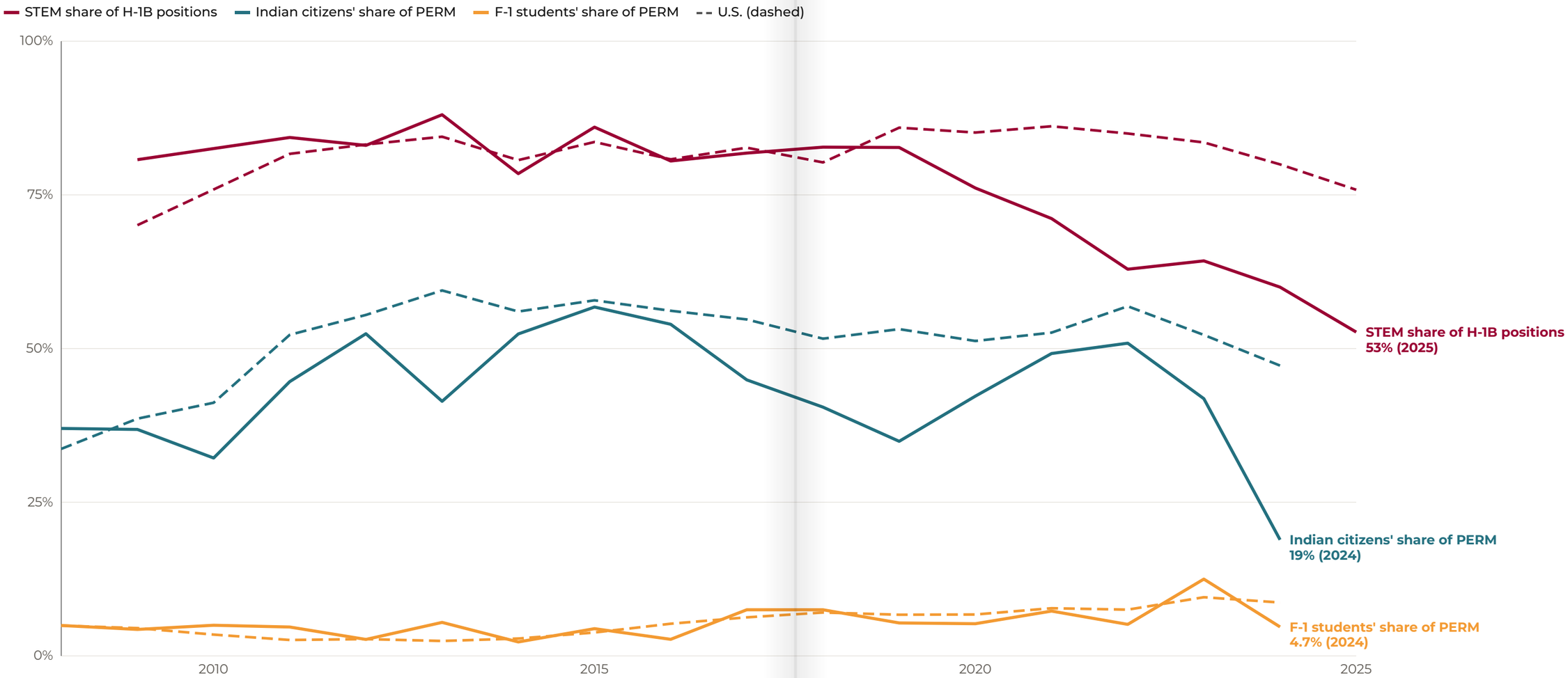
U.S. **138K** · **30th** of 51 · +96% since 2015

4.7%

PERM workers on F-1 student visas, 2024

U.S. **8.7%** · **43rd** of 51 · +0.3 pp since 2015

Figure 19 Who Holds Iowa's Skilled-Visa Jobs?



State solid, U.S. dashed. PERM citizenship and class of admission are not on the form DOL uses from FY2025. Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification.

53% of the state's certified H-1B positions were in STEM occupations in FY2025 (U.S. 76%).

Citizens of India held 19% of the state's PERM certifications in FY2024 (U.S. 47%). Under per-country caps they face the longest waits for a green card, so this share measures the state's exposure to the backlog.

53%

STEM share of H-1B positions, 2025

U.S. **76%** · **39th** of 51 · −33.3 pp since 2015

19%

PERM certifications for Indian citizens, 2024

U.S. **47%** · **40th** of 51 · −37.9 pp since 2015

$95K

Median offered H-1B wage (nominal), 2025

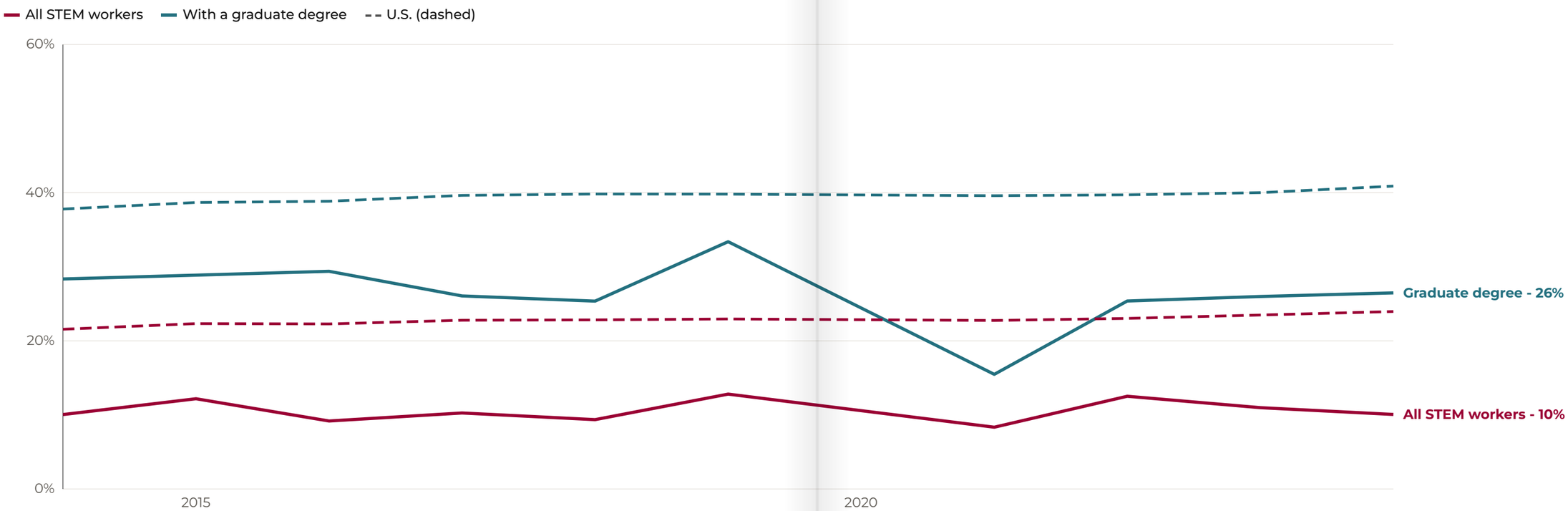
U.S. **$119K** · **34th** of 51 · +46% since 2015

SECTION 9

STEM Workforce

Iowa ranks 41st of 51 on the noncitizen share of STEM workers, at 4.7% in 2024 against 11% for the U.S.

Figure 20 How Much of Iowa's STEM Workforce Was Born Abroad?



Foreign-born share of employed workers in STEM occupations, by state of residence; state solid, U.S. dashed. Shares resting on fewer than 100 survey records are left out. No 2020 (experimental data). Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey.

In 2024, 10% of the people working in STEM occupations in Iowa were born abroad (U.S. 24%; 37th of 51).

The share rises with education: 26% of STEM workers with a graduate degree were foreign-born (U.S. 41%). 4.7% of all STEM workers were not U.S. citizens.

10%

Foreign-born share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **24%** · **37th** of 51 · −2.1 pp since 2015

26%

Foreign-born, STEM workers with grad degrees, 2024

U.S. **41%** · **26th** of 44 · −2.9 pp since 2016

4.7%

Noncitizen share of STEM workers, 2024

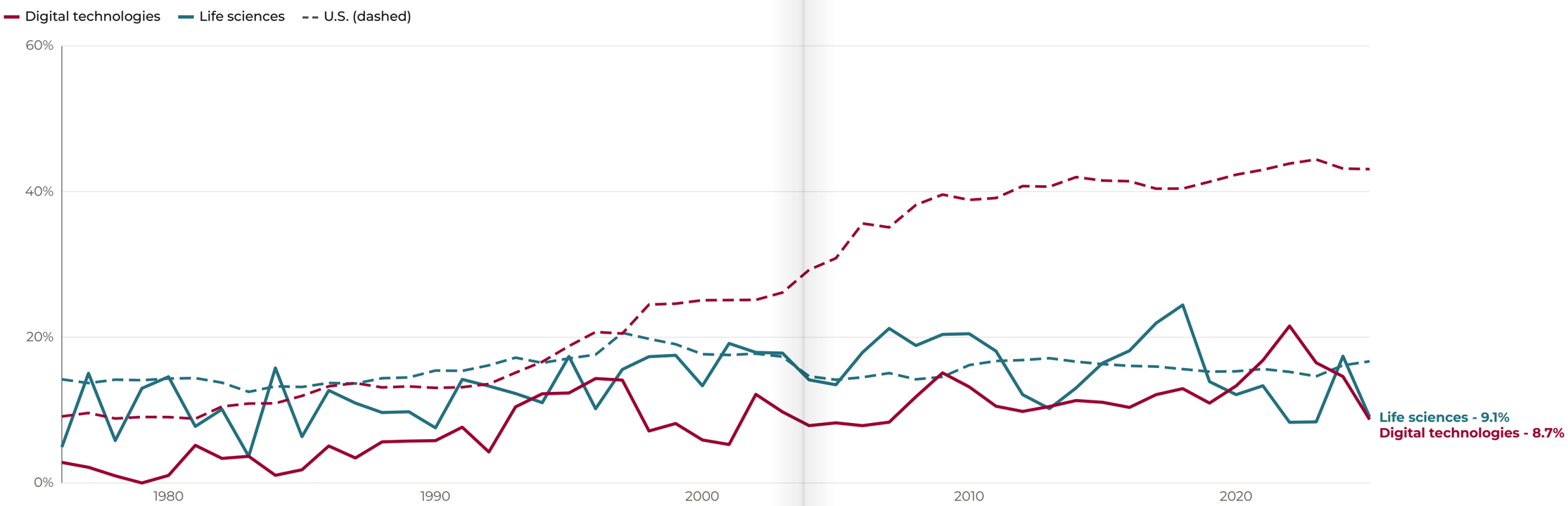
U.S. **11%** · **41st** of 51 · −3.0 pp since 2015

SECTION 10

Patents

Iowa ranks 47th of 51 on the share of the state's patents in digital technologies, at 8.7% in 2025 against 43% for the U.S.

Figure 21 What Kinds of Technology Does Iowa Patent?



Share of patents granted to owners in the state, by WIPO technology field of the first classification; state solid, U.S. dashed. Fractional counts by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live. Data from USPTO, PatentsView.

Organizations and people in Iowa were granted 1.14K U.S. patents in 2025, 0.9% of all patents with a U.S. owner (25th of 51).

8.7% were in digital technologies (U.S. 43%) and 9.1% in the life sciences (U.S. 17%).

1.14K

Patents granted to owners in the state, 2025

U.S. **135K** · **25th** of 51 · +19% since 2015

8.7%

Patents in digital technologies, 2025

U.S. **43%** · **47th** of 51 · −2.4 pp since 2015

9.1%

Patents in life sciences, 2025

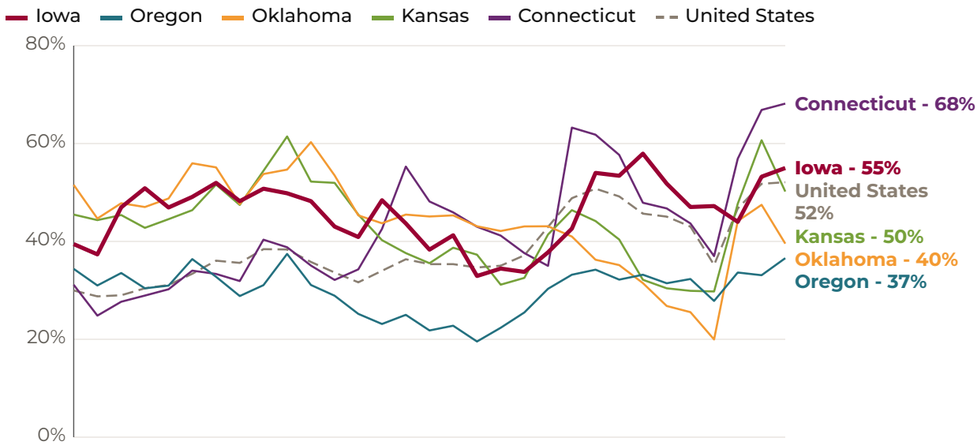
U.S. **17%** · **44th** of 51 · −7.4 pp since 2015

SECTION 11

Competitors

The four states closest in total fall enrollment, measured proportionally (a state 1.5 times as large counts as near as one two-thirds the size), are Oregon, Oklahoma, Kansas, and Connecticut. Iowa ranks 2nd of the five on the international share of STEM master's; Connecticut is the most dependent at 68%.

Figure 22 How Dependent Are Iowa and Its Peers on International STEM Master's?



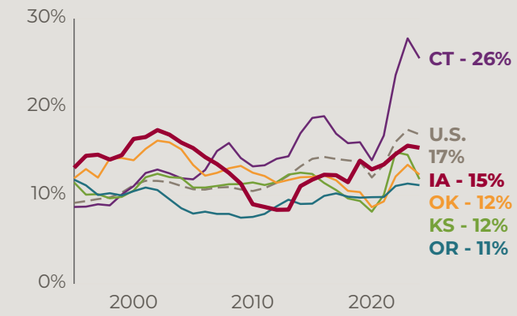
Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Table 4 How Does Iowa Compare With States of Similar Size?

Measure	IA	OR	OK	KS	CT	U.S.
Students enrolled, 2024	**207K**	203K	198K	196K	194K	19.7M
Graduate share of students, 2024	**13%**	13%	16%	14%	22%	17%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025	**22%**	29%	19%	20%	20%	24%
STEM share of master's, 2025	**17%**	21%	15%	17%	27%	23%
International STEM master's, 2025	**556**	470	508	629	2.83K	117K
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025	**0.5%**	0.4%	0.4%	0.5%	2.4%	–
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025	**55%**	37%	40%	50%	68%	52%
Int. share of STEM research doctorates, 2025	**46%**	18%	44%	52%	47%	43%
Int. share of grad students, 2024	**15%**	11%	12%	12%	26%	17%
Int. share of undergraduate enrollment, 2024	**2.7%**	1.6%	2.8%	3.6%	3.0%	3.0%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024	**69%**	66%	55%	58%	69%	65%
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023	**$10.9K**	$12.5K	$8.84K	$9.87K	$16.6K	$9.71K
Appropriations per student, 2024	**$9.86K**	$12.7K	$7.81K	$12K	$11.9K	$11.4K
Average faculty salary, 2024	**$88.1K**	$98.9K	$82.8K	$80.1K	$133K	$106K
First-time students from in state, 2024	**66%**	72%	72%	68%	61%	–
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024	**+23**	+7	+9	+16	−5	–

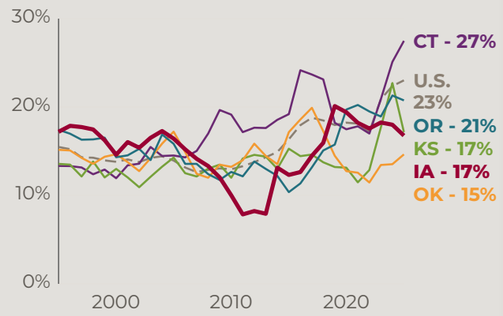
Latest year for each measure, given after its name. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 23 Int. share of grad students



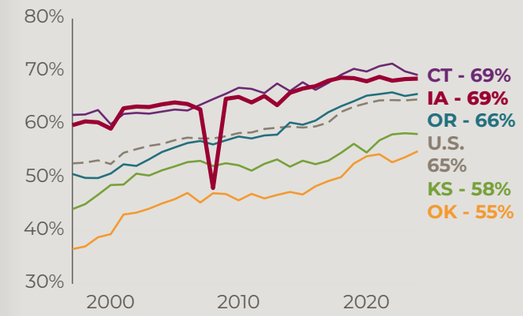
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 24 STEM share of master's



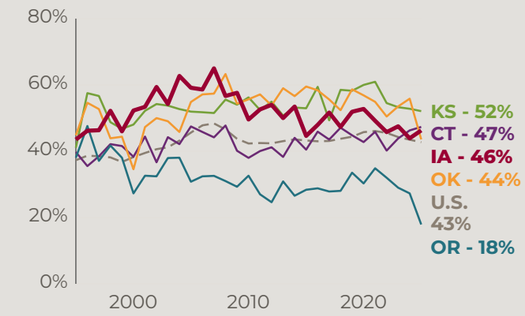
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 25 Six-year graduation rate



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 26 Int. share of STEM doctorates

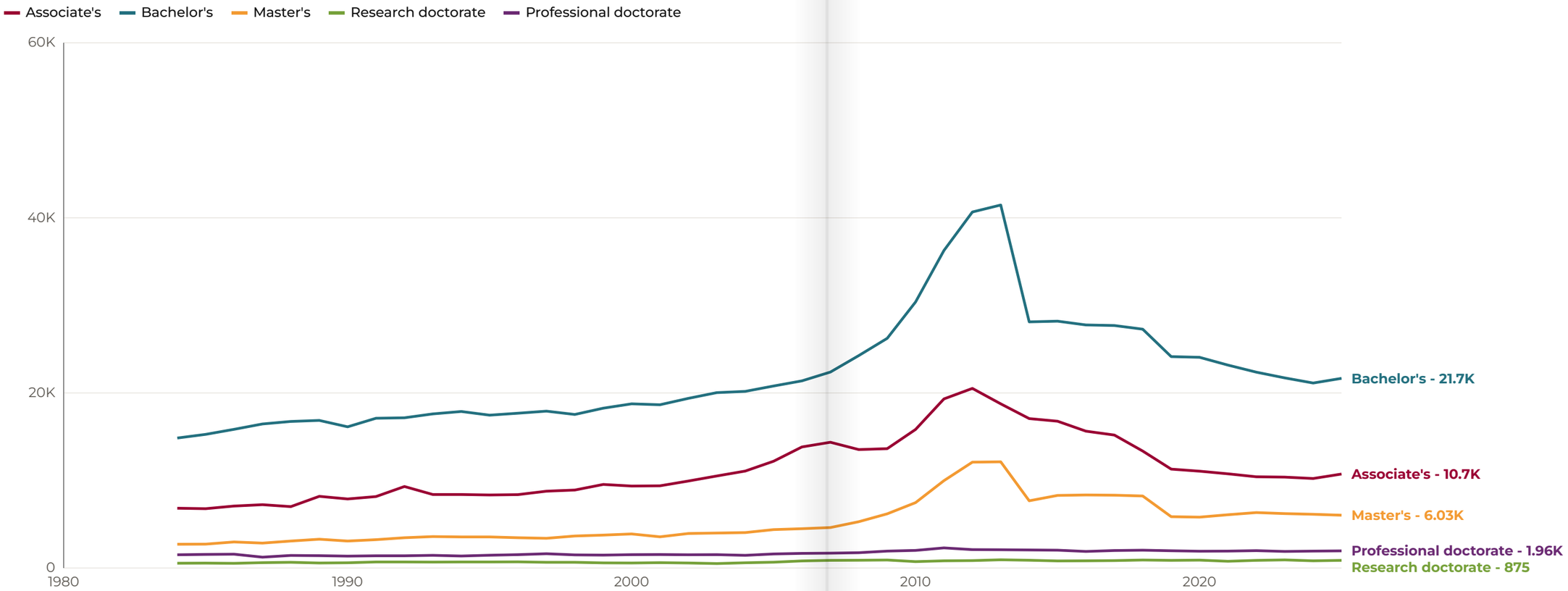


Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 12

Fields of Study

Figure 27 How Many Degrees Does Iowa Award?

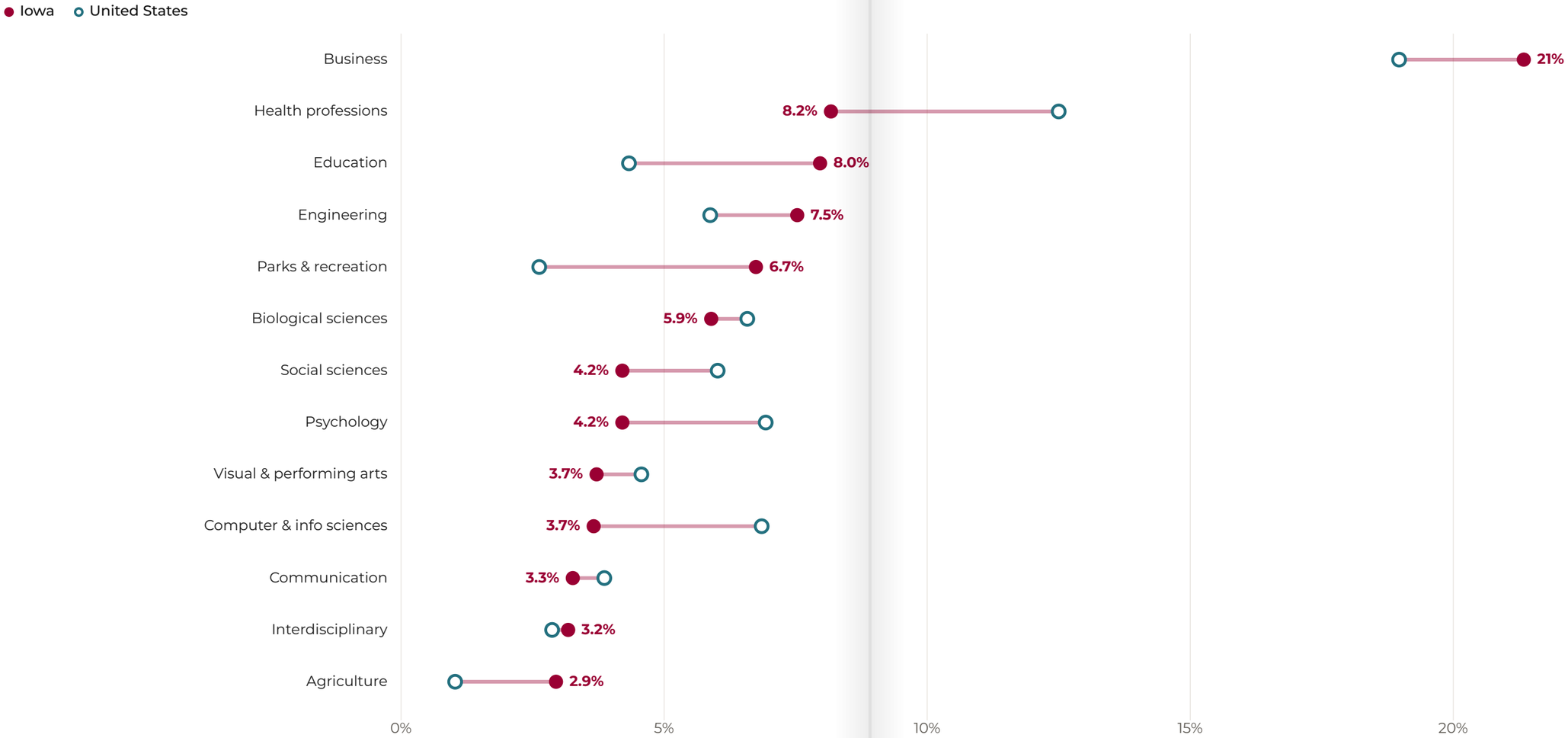


Degrees awarded by level, first majors. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

In 2025, Iowa's institutions awarded 10.7K associate's degrees, 21.7K bachelor's degrees, 6.03K master's degrees, 875 research doctorate degrees, 1.96K professional doctorate degrees.

Since 2015: associate's down 36%; bachelor's down 23%; master's down 27%; research doctorate up 7%; professional doctorate down 4%. The state awards 12.1 bachelor's degrees for every 100 undergraduates (U.S. 12.3).

Figure 28 What Do Iowa's Bachelor's Graduates Study?



Share of bachelor's degrees by field, 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Iowa's largest bachelor's fields are business (21%; U.S. 19%), health professions (8.2%; U.S. 13%), education (8.0%; U.S. 4.3%).

Relative to the nation, Iowa's bachelor's degrees are most concentrated in agriculture (2.87× the U.S. share), parks & recreation (2.57× the U.S. share), education (1.84× the U.S. share).

3.7%

Bachelor's in computer science, 2025

U.S. **6.9%** · **44th** of 51 · +1.4 pp since 2015

8.6%

Bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology, 2025

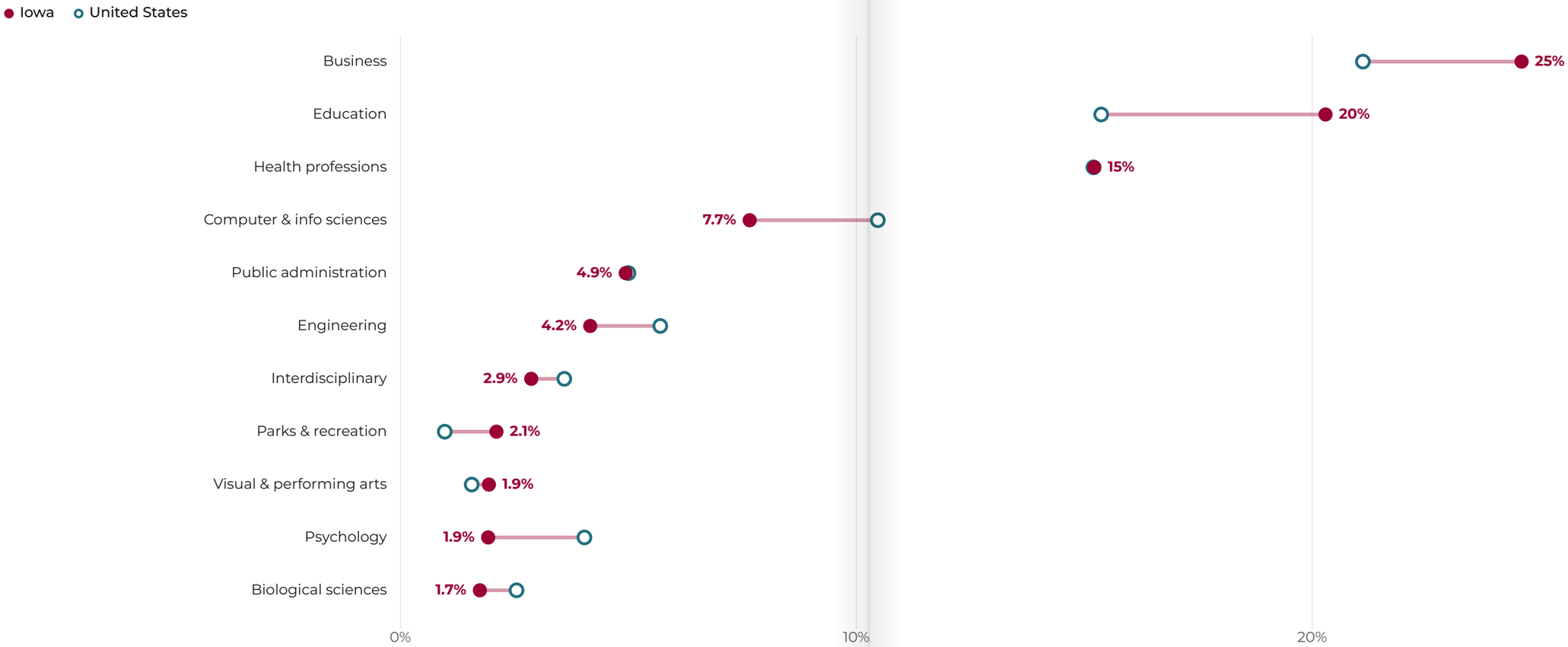
U.S. **6.8%** · **9th** of 51 · +2.1 pp since 2015

21%

Bachelor's in business, 2025

U.S. **19%** · **16th** of 51 · +1.1 pp since 2015

Figure 29 What Do Iowa's Master's Graduates Study?



Share of master's degrees by field, 2025; largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Iowa's largest master's fields are business (25%; U.S. 21%), education (20%; U.S. 15%), health professions (15%; U.S. 15%).

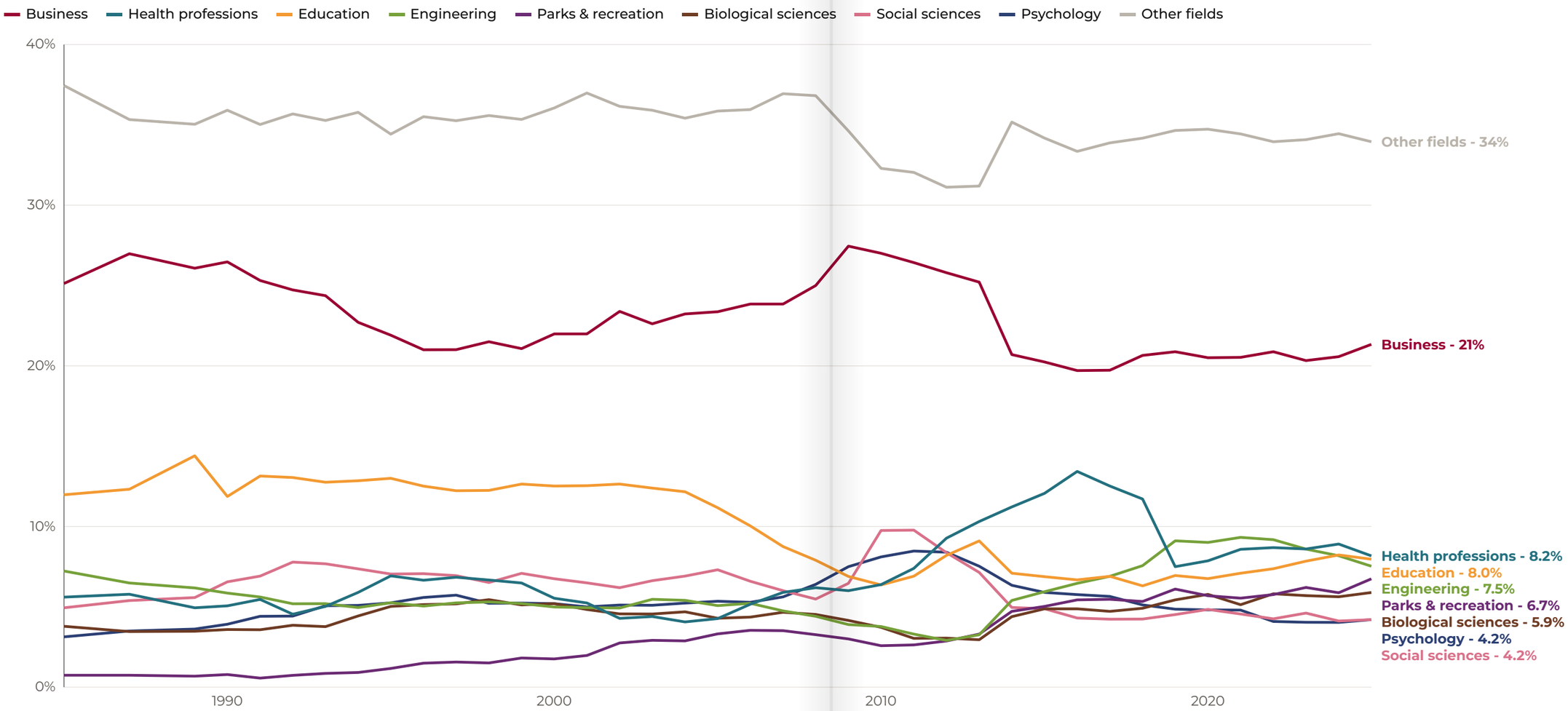
International students earn 16% of all master's degrees in the state (U.S. 22%), and STEM fields account for 17% of them.

17%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **36th** of 51 · +4.4 pp since 2015

16%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **24th** of 51 · +7.0 pp since 2015

81%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **11th** of 47 · +36.2 pp since 2015

Figure 30 How Has Iowa's Bachelor's Field Mix Changed?



Share of bachelor's degrees in the largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Since 2015, parks & recreation has gained the most ground, 1.7 points of the state's bachelor's degrees, while health professions lost the most (3.9 points).

The chart follows the share of bachelor's degrees in each of the state's largest fields; smaller fields are grouped as other fields.

SECTION 12 · FIELDS OF STUDY

Where Is Iowa Specialized, and What Do Its Doctoral Graduates Study?

The location quotient divides a field's share of Iowa's bachelor's degrees by its share of all U.S. bachelor's degrees in 2025. A quotient of 1.00 means the same share as the nation; 2.00 means twice the national share. The table lists the 10 fields with the highest quotients among fields with at least 50 degrees.

Highest location quotients. Agriculture (2.87, with 2.9% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 1.0% for the U.S.), parks & recreation (2.57, with 6.7% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 2.6% for the U.S.), and education (1.84, with 8.0% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 4.3% for the U.S.) had the highest quotients.

Table 5 Where Is Iowa Most Specialized?

Field	Location quotient	State share	U.S. share	Degrees
Agriculture	**2.87**	2.9%	1.0%	638
Parks & recreation	**2.57**	6.7%	2.6%	1.46K
Education	**1.84**	8.0%	4.3%	1.73K
English	**1.28**	1.9%	1.5%	417
Engineering	**1.28**	7.5%	5.9%	1.63K
Engineering technology	**1.20**	1.1%	0.9%	233
History	**1.18**	1.2%	1.0%	264
Family & consumer sci.	**1.15**	0.9%	0.8%	204
Public administration	**1.14**	1.7%	1.5%	364
Business	**1.13**	21%	19%	4.62K

Bachelor's degrees; location quotient = state share ÷ U.S. share; fields with 50+ degrees. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

22%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · **28th** of 51

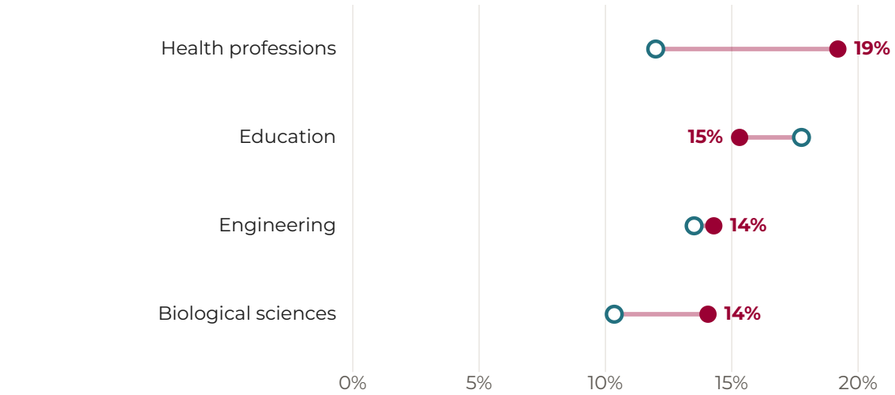
3.7%
Bachelor's in computer science, 2025
U.S. **6.9%** · **44th** of 51

8.6%
Bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology, 2025
U.S. **6.8%** · **9th** of 51

Each row is a field's share of the research doctorates awarded in Iowa in 2025 (filled dot), against its share nationally (open dot), for the ten largest fields with at least 20 doctorates. Research doctorates exclude professional doctorates such as the M.D. and J.D.

Largest doctoral fields. The state's largest doctoral fields were health professions (19% of research doctorates, against 12% for the U.S.), education (15% of research doctorates, against 18% for the U.S.), and engineering (14% of research doctorates, against 14% for the U.S.).

Figure 31 What Do Iowa's Doctoral Graduates Study?



Share of research doctorates by field, 2025; fields with 20+ doctorates. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

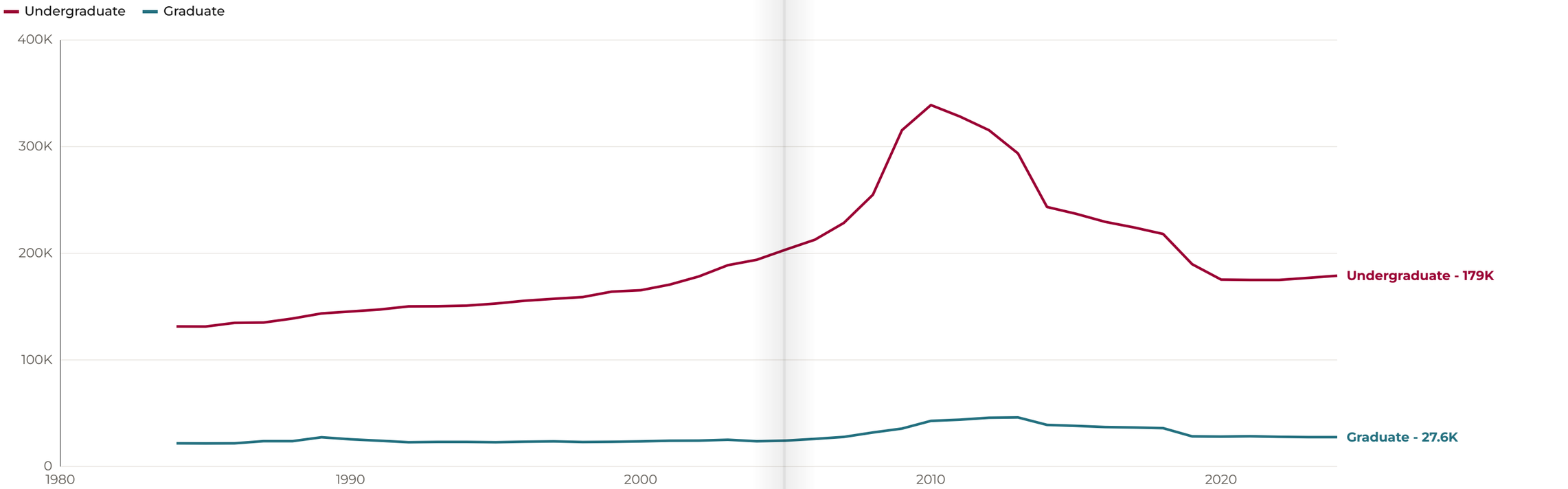
12

SECTION 13

Students and Money

Iowa ranks 37th of 51 on the share of students who are graduate students, at 13% in 2024 against 17% for the U.S.

Figure 32 How Has Enrollment Changed?



Fall headcount enrollment. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

In fall 2024, Iowa enrolled 179K undergraduates and 27.6K graduate students, 207K in all (29th of 51).

Undergraduate enrollment is down 24% since 2015 and graduate enrollment down 28% since 2015. Graduate students are 13% of all students (U.S. 17%).

207K

Students enrolled, 2024

U.S. **19.7M** · **29th** of 51 · −25% since 2015

13%

Graduate share of students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **37th** of 51 · −0.5 pp since 2015

38%

Students attending part-time, 2024

U.S. **39%** · **30th** of 51 · −4.1 pp since 2015

SECTION 13 · STUDENTS AND MONEY

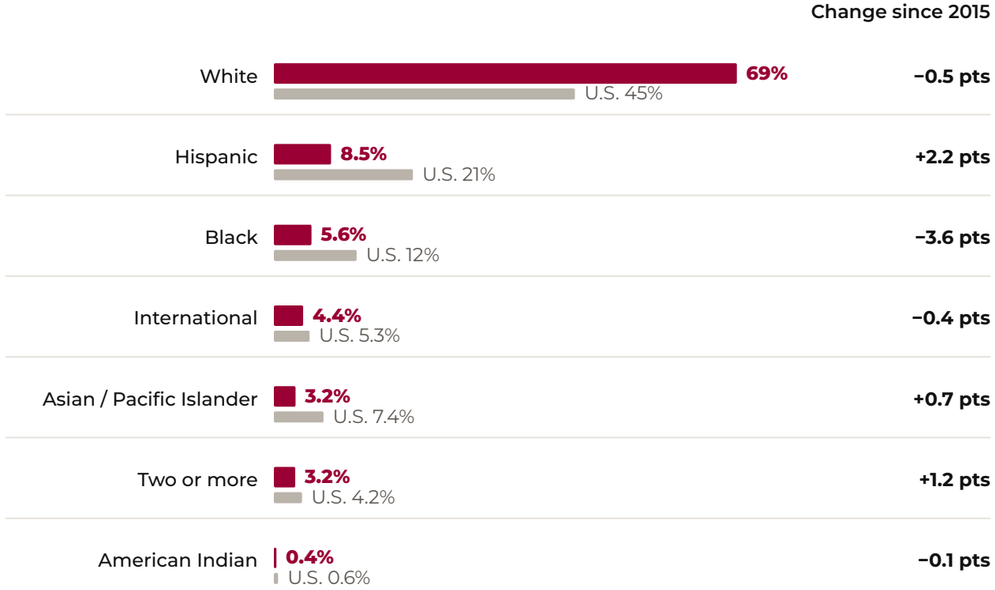
Who Enrolls in Iowa, and Where?

In fall 2024, White students were the largest group at Iowa's degree-granting institutions, **69%** of enrollment against 45% nationally, down 0.5 points since 2015.

Hispanic students were **8.5%** (U.S. 21%), up 2.2 points since 2015, and Black students were **5.6%** (U.S. 12%), down 3.6 points since 2015.

International students were **4.4%** (U.S. 5.3%), down 0.4 points since 2015, and Asian and Pacific Islander students were **3.2%** (U.S. 7.4%), up 0.7 points since 2015. "International" counts U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, whatever their race.

Figure 33 Who Enrolls in Iowa?



Share of fall 2024 headcount enrollment by race and ethnicity; students of unknown race are left out of the chart. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

69%
White students
U.S. **45%** · −0.5 pp since 2015

8.5%
Hispanic students
U.S. **21%** · +2.2 pp since 2015

42%
At public 2-year institutions
+8.3 pp since 2015

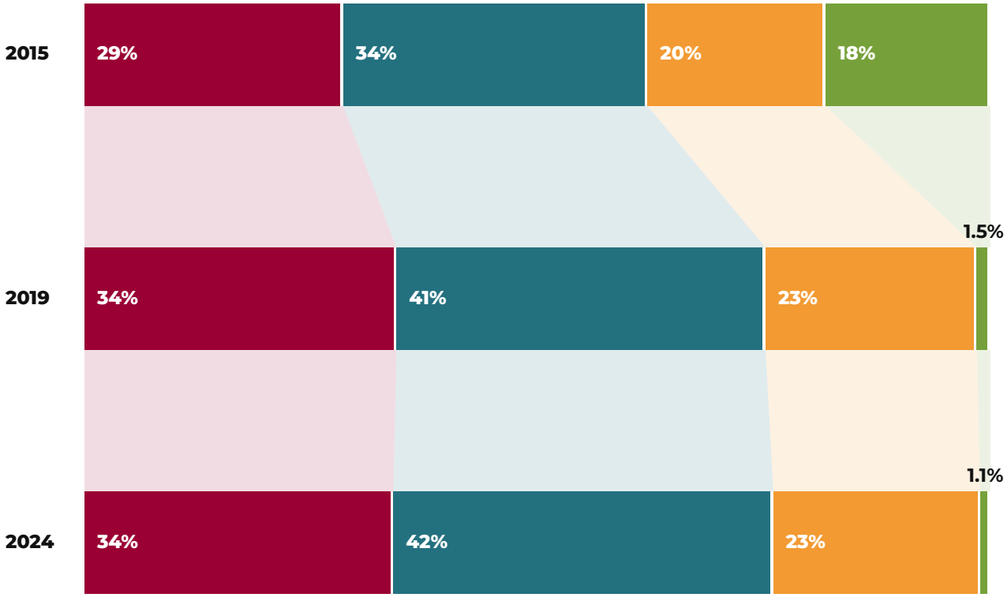
34%
At public 4-year institutions
+5.5 pp since 2015

In fall 2024, public 2-year institutions enrolled **42%** of students, up 8.3 points from 34% in 2015. Public 4-year institutions enrolled **34%** of students, up 5.5 points from 29% in 2015.

Private nonprofit institutions enrolled **23%** of students, up 3.2 points from 20% in 2015, and for-profit institutions enrolled **1.1%** of students, down 17.1 points from 18% in 2015.

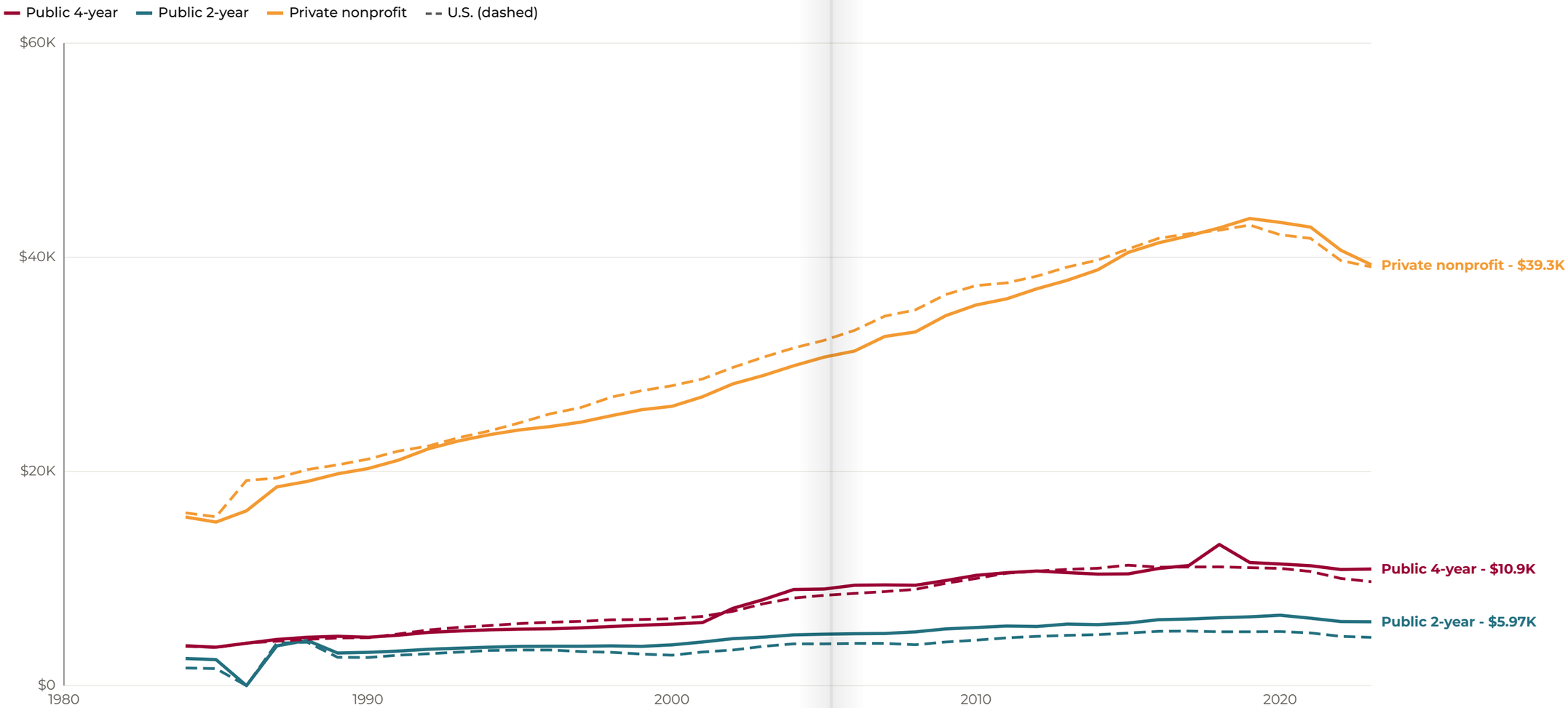
Public institutions together enrolled **76%** of students, against 73% nationally, 29th among the states.

Figure 34 Where Do Students Enroll?



Share of fall headcount enrollment by sector, 2015, 2019, 2024. Sectors as IPEDS classifies them each year. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 35 What Does In-State Tuition Cost?



Published in-state tuition and fees, 2024 dollars (CPI-U); state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

In-state tuition and fees at Iowa's public four-year institutions are $10.9K (2023, 2024 dollars), 12% above the U.S. ($9.71K); the state ranks 20th of 51.

State and local appropriations come to $9.86K per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions (34th of 51), and net tuition makes up 51% of net tuition plus state and local appropriations (U.S. 43%).

$10.9K

In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023

U.S. **$9.71K** · **20th** of 51 · +4.3% since 2015

$9.86K

Appropriations per student, 2024

U.S. **$11.4K** · **34th** of 51 · −4.4% since 2015

51%

Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations, 2024

U.S. **43%** · **18th** of 51 · +1.5 pp since 2015

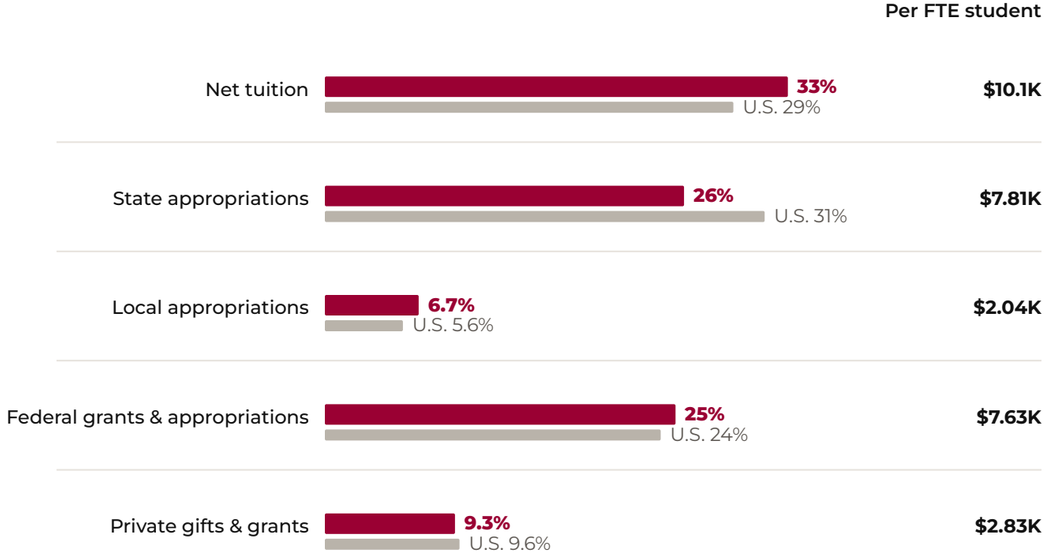
SECTION 13 · STUDENTS AND MONEY

How Are Iowa's Public Institutions Funded, and What Do They Produce?

The bars give each source's share of the core revenue of Iowa's public institutions, with the nation for comparison, and at right the dollars per full-time-equivalent (FTE) student it provides. Values are in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Net tuition is tuition and fees after institutional discounts and allowances.

Net tuition per FTE student. The figure was $10.1K in FY2024, against $8.96K for the U.S., down 0.9% from $10.2K in FY2023 and up 1.5% since FY2015, when it was $9.92K.

Figure 36 How Are Public Institutions Funded?



Share of core revenue per FTE student by source, public institutions, FY2024; dollars per FTE at right, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Shares are of all five sources; the tuition share elsewhere in this profile divides net tuition by net tuition plus state and local appropriations only. Data from NCES, IPEDS Finance.

$10.9K
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023
U.S. **$9.71K** · **20th** of 51

$9.86K
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · **34th** of 51

51%
Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations, 2024
U.S. **43%** · **18th** of 51

The table brings together five measures of what public higher education costs and what it produces in Iowa: in-state tuition at public four-year institutions, state and local appropriations per full-time-equivalent student, tuition's share of public institutions' core revenue, the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, and the average full-time faculty salary.

In-state tuition, public 4-year. The figure was $10.9K in 2023, against $9.71K for the U.S., 20th among the states, up 0.4% from $10.8K in 2022 and up 4.3% since 2015, when it was $10.4K.

Table 6 Money and Results

Measure	Year	Iowa	U.S.	Rank	Change since 2015
In-state tuition, public 4-year	2023	**$10.9K**	$9.71K	20th of 51	+4.3%
Appropriations per student	2024	**$9.86K**	$11.4K	34th of 51	−4.4%
Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations	2024	**51%**	43%	18th of 51	+1.5 pp
Six-year graduation rate	2024	**69%**	65%	9th of 51	+1.9 pp
Average faculty salary	2024	**$88.1K**	$106K	36th of 51	−12%

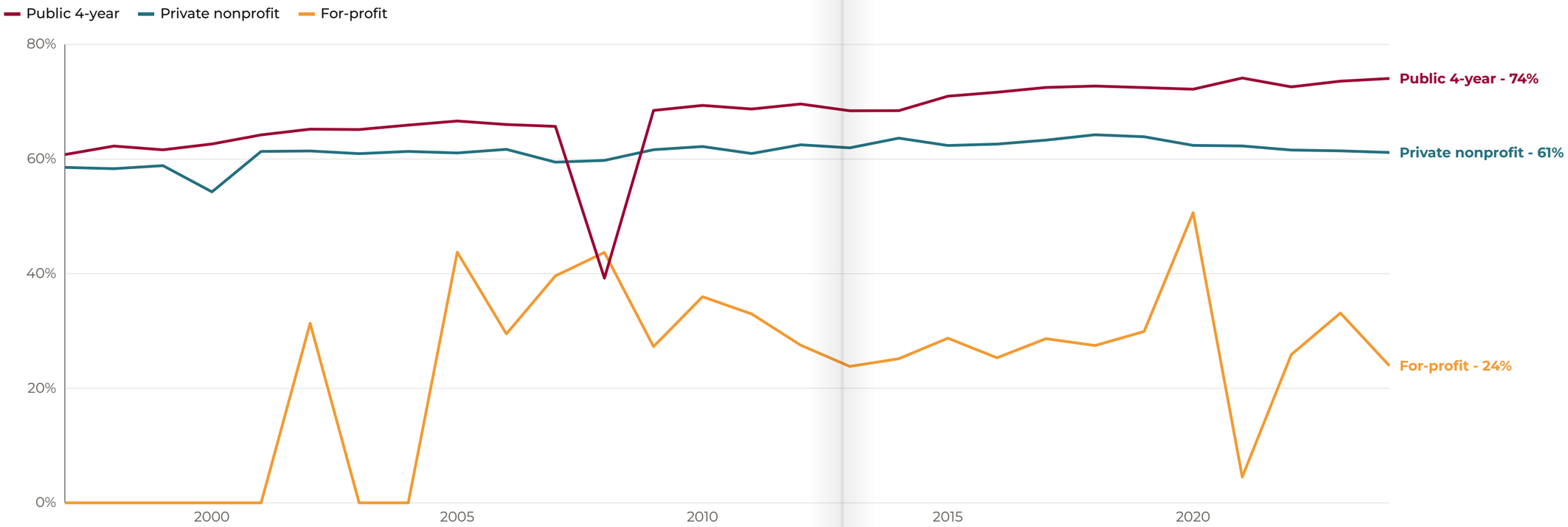
Rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Dollars in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 14

Student Outcomes

Iowa ranks 9th of 51 on the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions, at 69% in 2024 against 65% for the U.S.

Figure 37 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Sector?



Six-year bachelor's graduation rate by sector of institution. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

69% of students who started a bachelor's degree at a four-year institution in Iowa graduated within six years (2024), 3.9 points above the U.S. (65%); the state ranks 9th of 51.

By sector: public 4-year 74%, private nonprofit 61%, for-profit 24%. At two-year institutions, 44% complete within 150% of normal time (U.S. 41%).

69%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **9th** of 51 · +1.9 pp since 2015

44%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **16th** of 50 · +15.9 pp since 2015

12.1
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **33rd** of 51 · +0.5 since 2015

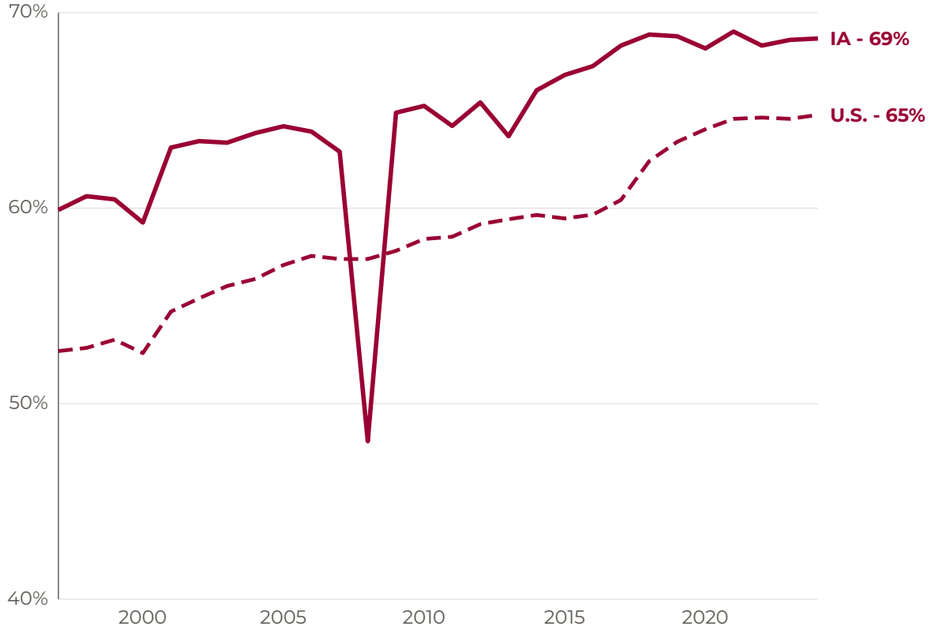
SECTION 14 · STUDENT OUTCOMES

How Many of Iowa's Students Graduate?

The line follows the share of first-time, full-time bachelor's-degree students at Iowa's four-year institutions who graduated from the institution where they started within six years (150% of normal time). Each year is the cohort that entered six years earlier. The rate leaves out students who start part-time (38% of the state's students attend part-time, against 39% nationally) and students who transfer and finish elsewhere. The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Six-year graduation rate. The rate was 69% in 2024, against 65% for the U.S., up 0.1 points from 69% in 2023 and up 1.9 points since 2015, when it was 67%.

Figure 38 Six-Year Bachelor's Graduation Rate



Four-year institutions; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

69%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **9th** of 51

44%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **16th** of 50

12.1
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **33rd** of 51

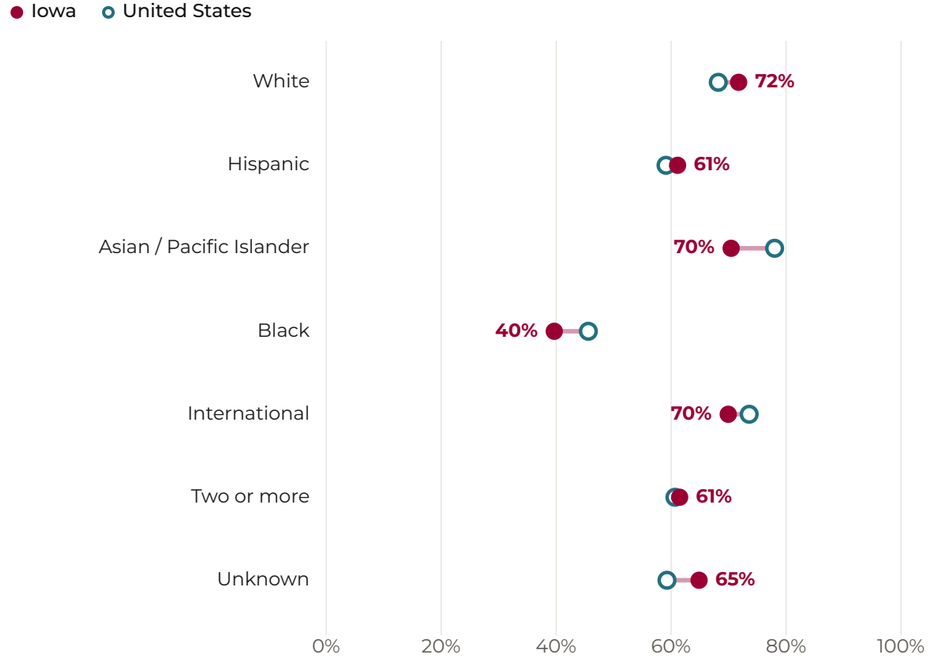
Each row is the six-year bachelor's graduation rate for one racial or ethnic group of students at Iowa's four-year institutions (filled dot), against the national rate for the same group (open dot). Groups with fewer than 100 students in the cohort are left out.

White. The six-year rate was 72% in 2024, against 68% for the U.S.

Hispanic. The six-year rate was 61% in 2024, against 59% for the U.S.

Asian / Pacific Islander. The six-year rate was 70% in 2024, against 78% for the U.S.

Figure 39 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Race and Ethnicity?



Six-year rate, 2024; groups with 100+ students. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

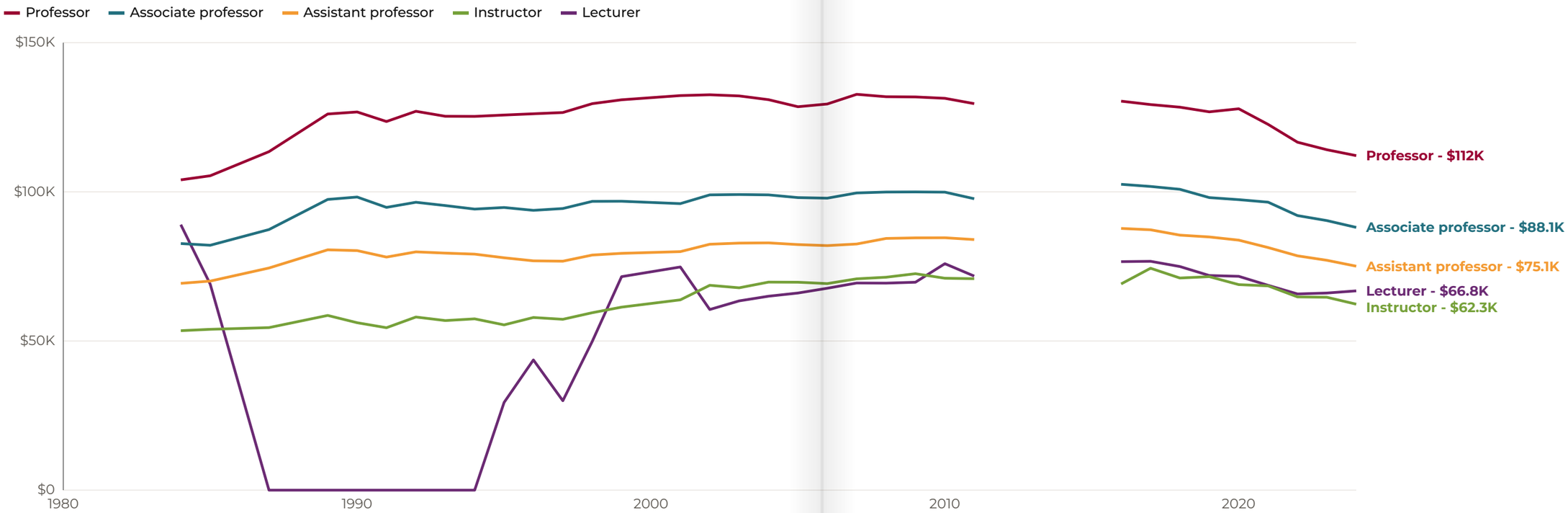
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SECTION 15

Faculty

Iowa ranks 36th of 51 on the average full-time faculty salary, at $88.1K in 2024 against $106K for the U.S.

Figure 40 What Do Iowa's Faculty Earn, by Rank?



Average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts, by academic rank, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS Human Resources.

Full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts at Iowa's institutions earned an average of $88.1K in 2024 (2024 dollars), 17% below the U.S. ($106K); the state ranks 36th of 51. By rank (2024): professors $112K, associate professors $88.1K, assistant professors $75.1K, instructors $62.3K, lecturers $66.8K.

Iowa's institutions had 8.75K full-time instructional staff in 2024, down 10% since 2015. Average salary across all ranks is down 12% since 2016.

$88.1K

Average faculty salary, 2024

U.S. **$106K** · **36th** of 51 · −12% since 2016

SECTION 15 · FACULTY

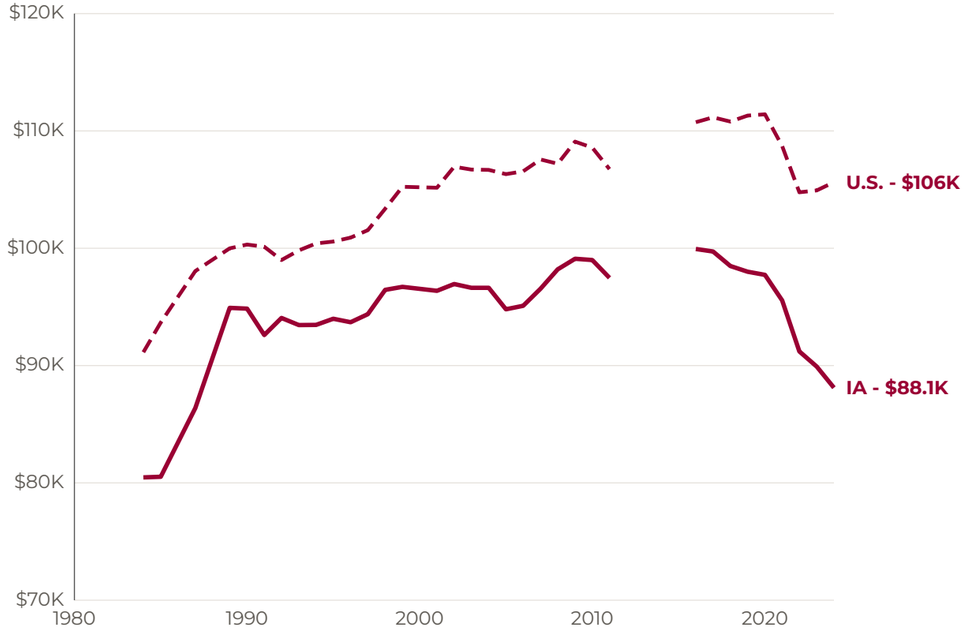
What Do Iowa's Faculty Earn, and How Many Hold Tenure?

The line follows the average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9- or 10-month contracts at Iowa's degree-granting institutions, all ranks combined, in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Average salary. The figure was $88.1K in 2024, against $106K for the U.S., 36th among the states, down 2.0% from $89.9K in 2023 and down 12% since 2016, when it was $99.9K.

Full-time instructional staff. The number was 8.75K in 2024, down 0.4% from 8.78K in 2023 and down 9.9% since 2015, when it was 9.71K.

Figure 41 Average Faculty Salary



Full-time instructional faculty, 9/10-month, 2024 dollars. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

$88.1K
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · **36th** of 51

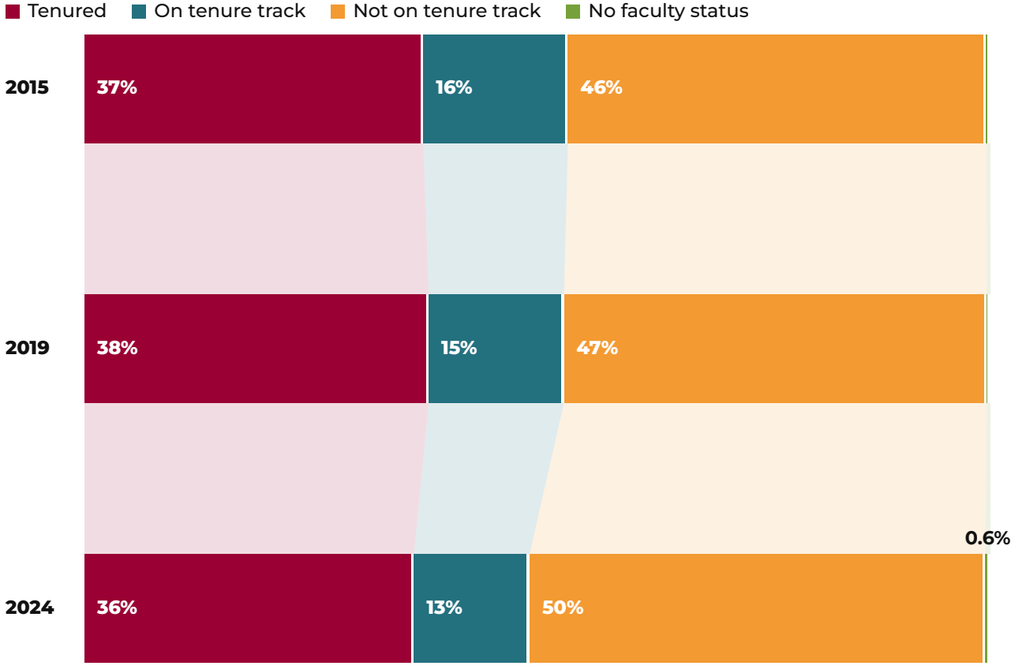
8.75K
Full-time instructional staff, 2024

36%
Tenured, 2024

The bars divide Iowa's full-time instructional staff by tenure status in 2015, 2019 and 2024: tenured, on the tenure track, not on the tenure track (for example, lecturers on fixed-term contracts), and staff at institutions with no tenure system.

Tenured, share of full-time instructional staff. The share was 36% in 2024, down 0.6 points from 37% in 2023 and down 1.0 point since 2015, when it was 37%.

Figure 42 Tenure Status



Full-time instructional staff by tenure status, 2015, 2019, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

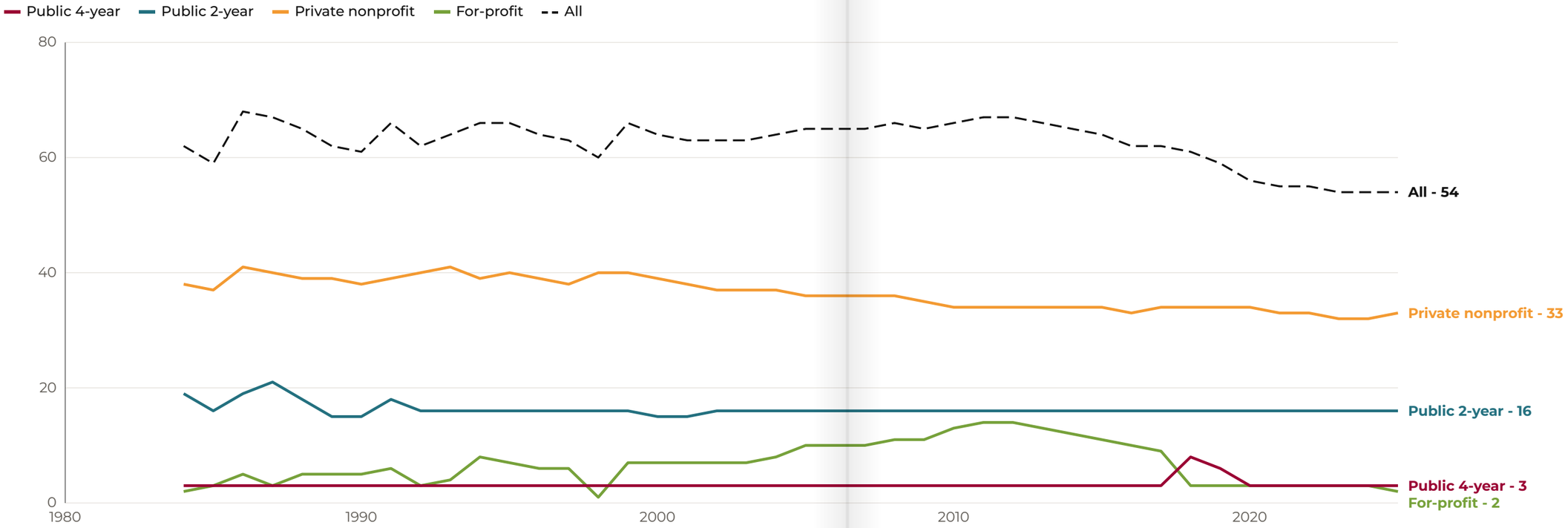
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SECTION 16

Institutions

Iowa ranks 44th of 51 on the share of students enrolled exclusively online, at 19% in 2024 against 27% for the U.S.

Figure 43 How Many Institutions Does Iowa Have?



Degree-granting institutions by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Iowa has 54 degree-granting institutions:3 public 4-year, 16 public 2-year, 33 private nonprofit, 2 for-profit (2025).

The number of institutions is down 16% since 2015. 76% of students attend public institutions and 1.1% attend for-profit ones.

76%

Students at public institutions, 2024

U.S. **73%** · **29th** of 51 · +13.9 pp since 2015

1.1%

Students at for-profit institutions, 2024

U.S. **5.5%** · **31st** of 51 · −17.1 pp since 2015

19%

Students fully online, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **44th** of 51 · −6.9 pp since 2015

SECTION 16 · INSTITUTIONS

Which Institutions Lead in Iowa?

The table ranks institutions in Iowa by the STEM master's degrees and research doctorates they awarded to international students in 2025, the two counted together. The share columns give international students' share of each institution's STEM degrees at that level.

Largest. Iowa State University (182 international STEM master's degrees and 124 doctorates), Maharishi International University (298 international STEM master's degrees and – doctorates), and University of Iowa (71 international STEM master's degrees and 51 doctorates) awarded the most.

Table 7 Which Institutions Train the Most International STEM Graduates?

Institution	STEM total	STEM master's	Int. share	STEM doctorates	Int. share
Iowa State University Ames · Public 4-year	**306**	182	50%	124	61%
Maharishi International University Fairfield · Private nonprofit	**298**	298	87%	–	–%
University of Iowa Iowa City · Public 4-year	**122**	71	29%	51	30%
University of Northern Iowa Cedar Falls · Public 4-year	**4**	4	12%	–	–
Graceland University-Lamoni Lamoni · Private nonprofit	**1**	1	33%	–	–

Ranked by the total (shaded) of international STEM master's degrees and research doctorates. Degrees awarded in 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

54
Degree-granting institutions, 2025

76%
Students at public institutions, 2024
U.S. **73%** · **29th** of 51

1.1%
Students at for-profit institutions, 2024
U.S. **5.5%** · **31st** of 51

19%
Students fully online, 2024
U.S. **27%** · **44th** of 51

The table lists Iowa's largest degree-granting institutions by fall 2024 headcount enrollment, with the international share of graduate students, STEM bachelor's degrees awarded in 2025, the six-year graduation rate and the admission rate (a dash where the institution admits all applicants or does not report one).

Largest. The three largest were University of Iowa (30.8K students), Iowa State University (30.4K students), and Des Moines Area Community College (23.7K students).

Degree-granting institutions. The state had 54 in 2025, and 54 of them reported the enrollment and degree data in these tables.

Table 8 What Are Iowa's Largest Institutions?

Institution	Enrollment	Int. share, grad	STEM bachelor's	Six-year grad rate	Admit rate
University of Iowa	**30.8K**	14%	929	75%	84%
Iowa State University	**30.4K**	40%	2.19K	75%	89%
Des Moines Area Community College	**23.7K**	–	–	–	–
Kirkwood Community College	**12.8K**	–	–	–	–
University of Northern Iowa	**9.28K**	6.4%	214	68%	93%
Eastern Iowa Community College District	**7.43K**	–	–	–	–
Iowa Western Community College	**5.54K**	–	–	–	–
Western Iowa Tech Community College	**5.48K**	–	–	–	–
Hawkeye Community College	**5.12K**	–	–	–	–
Iowa Central Community College	**4.95K**	–	–	–	–

Fall 2024 enrollment; degrees 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

NOTES

About These Data

International students

U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, as IPEDS defines them. IPEDS does not record country of citizenship. Permanent residents count with U.S. citizens.

STEM

CIP families 03, 04, 11, 14, 15, 26, 27 and 40. Doctorates are research and scholarship doctorates; professional doctorates appear only in the degree-count figure. Degrees are first majors only.

Universe

Degree-granting institutions located in the state; Title IV participants from 1996. Geography is the institution's location, not the student's home. Enrollment is fall headcount.

Migration

First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by home state, reported in even years before 2001 and every year since; odd years with incomplete reporting are omitted. Net migration is students arriving from other states minus residents leaving, per 100 resident first-time students.

Money

Tuition, appropriations, revenue and faculty salaries are in 2024 dollars using the CPI-U. Research funding (HERD, Federal Funds, USAspending), wages and the NAFSA economic contribution are nominal dollars, and are labeled so. Appropriations and revenue are per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions; the tuition share divides net tuition by net tuition plus state and local appropriations.

Race and ethnicity

IPEDS did not collect race and ethnicity in every year before 2010, and categories changed in 2008–2010; “Two or more” exists only from then.

Countries of citizenship

From DHS SEVIS by the Numbers: active F-1 and M-1 student records in the month named, at every level from primary school to doctorate, by the state of the school. IPEDS records only whether a student is a U.S. nonresident, not where they come from. SEVIS counts are monthly snapshots and are not directly comparable with IPEDS fall enrollment or degree counts. Year-to-year comparisons use one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November).

Peers

Comparison states are the four closest in total fall enrollment, measured proportionally: a state 1.5 times as large counts as near as one two-thirds the size.

Sources

IPEDS (National Center for Education Statistics) is the backbone: Institutional Characteristics, Fall Enrollment, Completions, Graduation Rates, Finance, Human Resources and Admissions, 1980–2025, harmonized into a state panel. The profile also draws on NAEP, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates, Survey of Earned Doctorates, HERD and Federal Funds surveys, USAspending.gov, DHS SEVIS by the Numbers and ICE SEVIS releases, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification and BLS wage data, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes, USPTO PatentsView, and other federal sources; every figure names its source, and the Sources page lists them in full. Generated November 2026.

NOTES

How the Numbers Are Counted

Ranks

Ranks are among the 50 states and the District of Columbia (1 = highest value, whether or not a high value is good). Where fewer than 51 report, the count is given ("23rd of 33").

Sectors

Sectors are as IPEDS classifies institutions each year. IPEDS moves a whole institution to "public, 4-year or above" once it awards any bachelor's degree, so community colleges that began offering applied bachelor's degrees carry all of their students into the public 4-year sector. Sector series (enrollment shares, public 4-year tuition, graduation rates by sector) reflect these moves.

Research doctorates

Two counts appear. IPEDS counts degrees institutions report as "doctor's degree, research/scholarship", which includes some practice-oriented degrees such as many Ed.D.s; the NSF Survey of Earned Doctorates counts research doctorate recipients and is smaller. Each figure names which it uses. "STEM master's per STEM research doctorate" divides IPEDS STEM master's degrees by IPEDS STEM research doctorates.

Engineering

"Engineering" alone is CIP 14. Where engineering technology (CIP 15) is added, the label says "engineering & eng. technology".

Graduation rates

IPEDS graduation rates follow first-time, full-time students and count only those who finish at the institution where they started, so they leave out part-time starters and students who transfer and finish elsewhere.

International students in SEVIS

SEVIS counts active F-1 and M-1 records, which include graduates on Optional Practical Training (up to 36 months for STEM graduates, 12 for others), so STEM shares run high. STEM follows the DHS STEM Designated Degree Program List, which is broader than the eight CIP families above, and DHS draws its STEM pages on a different basis from its all-student pages, so a country's STEM count can exceed its all-level count.

Visas and green cards

DOL labor condition applications (H-1B positions) are counted by worksite and include renewals and job changes; USCIS approvals are counted by the employer's address and split into new and continuing. PERM certifications are the employer's step toward a green card.

Patents

Patents are counted by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live; a company headquartered in another state takes its patents there.

Years

Each measure uses its latest year, so years differ across a page; every figure, table and statement gives its year, and lines that stop early are labeled with their last year.

Iowa – By the Numbers

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION							
Grade 8 mathematics, average score	286	**275**[2024]	−11.6 ▼	272	−9.0 ▼	#23	[5]
Grade 8 mathematics: at or above Proficient	37%	**27%**[2024]	−10.1 pp ▼	27%	−5.3 pp ▼	#24	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics, average score	243	**237**[2024]	−6.3 ▼	237	−2.5 ▼	#30	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics: at or above Proficient	44%	**39%**[2024]	−5.4 pp ▼	39%	0.0 pp	#27	[5]
Grade 8 reading, average score	268	**261**[2024]	−7.5 ▼	257	−7.3 ▼	#10	[5]
Grade 8 reading: at or above Proficient	36%	**31%**[2024]	−4.5 pp ▼	29%	−4.0 pp ▼	#15	[5]
Grade 4 reading, average score	224	**215**[2024]	−9.0 ▼	214	−7.1 ▼	#26	[5]
Grade 8 science, average score, 2009 framework	–	**159**[2015]	–	153	–	#15	[5]
Current spending per public-school pupil	$14.3K	**$15K**[2021]	+4.5% ▲	$16.8K	+12% ▲	#31	[3]
Public high school 4-year graduation rate, ACGR	91%	**90%**[2022]	−1.0 pp ▼	87%	+4.0 pp ▲	#2	[3]
Public high school graduates	32.6K	**35.6K**[2024]	+9.4% ▲	3.49M	+8.8% ▲	#31	[3]
Average public-school teacher salary	$69.9K	**$65.1K**[2022]	−6.9% ▼	$72.9K	−3.0% ▼	#25	[3]
Pupils per teacher, public schools	14.2	**14.1**[2022]	−0.1 ▼	15.4	−0.6 ▼	#27	[3]
Public elementary and secondary enrollment	508K	**504K**[2024]	−0.7% ▼	49.4M	−2.1% ▼	#31	[3]
Public-school students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch	41%	**42%**[2023]	+1.0 pp ▲	53%	+1.5 pp ▲	#36	[3]
English learners as a share of public-school students	5.3%	**6.2%**[2022]	+0.9 pp ▲	11%	+1.0 pp ▲	#32	[3]
Charter-school share of public-school enrollment	0.1%	**0.0%**[2023]	−0.1 pp ▼	7.6%	+2.2 pp ▲	#45	[3]
High schools offering calculus	71%[2016]	**70%**[2024]	−0.4 pp ▼	51%	−5.8 pp ▼	#5	[14]
High schools offering physics	93%[2016]	**91%**[2024]	−1.7 pp ▼	64%	−2.4 pp ▼	#2	[14]
High schools offering chemistry	92%[2016]	**93%**[2024]	+0.5 pp ▲	81%	+0.7 pp ▲	#8	[14]
High schools offering Algebra II	91%[2016]	**95%**[2024]	+3.6 pp ▲	87%	+1.3 pp ▲	#9	[14]
High schools offering computer science	83%[2021]	**91%**[2024]	+7.9 pp ▲	55%	+2.0 pp ▲	#2	[14]
High schools offering any AP course	47%[2016]	**45%**[2024]	−2.0 pp ▼	56%	0.0 pp	#36	[14]
High schools offering AP computer science	11%[2021]	**16%**[2024]	+4.8 pp ▲	25%	+2.6 pp ▲	#35	[14]

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IOWA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION (CONTINUED)							
High schools offering dual enrollment	91%[2016]	**92%[2024]**	+0.5 pp ▲	71%	+11.1 pp ▲	#2	[14]
AP course enrollments per 100 high-school students	10.1[2016]	**10.8[2024]**	+0.7 ▲	18.4	+1.0 ▲	#46	[14]
Calculus enrollments per 100 high-school students	2.9[2016]	**2.4[2024]**	−0.5 ▼	3.3	−1.0 ▼	#34	[14]
Physics enrollments per 100 high-school students	15.2[2016]	**18.9[2024]**	+3.7 ▲	9.4	−0.4 ▼	#2	[14]
SAT or ACT takers per 100 high-school students	17.4[2016]	**9.9[2024]**	−7.5 ▼	18.1	−2.5 ▼	#46	[14]
Students in gifted and talented programs per 100 students	9.0[2016]	**8.3[2024]**	−0.8 ▼	7.0	+0.4 ▲	#15	[14]
ENROLLMENT AND INSTITUTIONS							
Pell Grant share of undergraduates	29%	**27%[2025]**	−2.3 pp ▼	36%	−0.8 pp ▼	#48	[15]
Fall enrollment	275K	**207K[2024]**	−25% ▼	19.7M	−1.7% ▼	#29	[4]
Share of enrollment at public institutions	62%	**76%[2024]**	+13.9 pp ▲	73%	0.0 pp	#29	[4]
Share of enrollment at for-profit institutions	18%	**1.1%[2024]**	−17.1 pp ▼	5.5%	−1.2 pp ▼	#31	[4]
Share of students enrolled part-time	42%	**38%[2024]**	−4.1 pp ▼	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#30	[4]
Share of students who are graduate students	14%	**13%[2024]**	−0.5 pp ▼	17%	+2.0 pp ▲	#37	[4]
Share of students enrolled exclusively online	26%	**19%[2024]**	−6.9 pp ▼	27%	+12.1 pp ▲	#44	[4]
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY							
Research doctorates awarded	686	**687[2025]**	+0.1% ▲	59K	+7.3% ▲	#25	[7]
Science & engineering research doctorates, excluding health	475	**524[2025]**	+10% ▲	44.4K	+14% ▲	#25	[7]
Share of U.S. research doctorates	1.2%	**1.2%[2025]**	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#25	[7]
Engineering research doctorates	113	**121[2025]**	+7.1% ▲	10.9K	+9.9% ▲	#24	[7]
Mathematics & computer science research doctorates	46	**71[2025]**	–	5.07K	+33% ▲	#19	[7]
STEM master's degrees per research doctorate	2.7	**2.7[2025]**	−0.1 ▼	6.4	+2.1 ▲	#48	[4]
STEM share of bachelor's	17%	**22%[2025]**	+5.1 pp ▲	24%	+5.3 pp ▲	#28	[4]
Share of bachelor's in computer & information sciences	2.2%	**3.7%[2025]**	+1.4 pp ▲	6.9%	+3.7 pp ▲	#44	[4]
Share of bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	6.5%	**8.6%[2025]**	+2.1 pp ▲	6.8%	+0.7 pp ▲	#9	[4]
Share of bachelor's in mathematics & statistics	1.3%	**1.0%[2025]**	−0.3 pp ▼	1.2%	0.0 pp	#20	[4]

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IOWA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY (CONTINUED)							
Share of bachelor's in biological & biomedical sciences	4.9%	**5.9%**[2025]	+1.0 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#33	[4]
Share of bachelor's in physical sciences	1.0%	**1.3%**[2025]	+0.3 pp ▲	1.3%	−0.3 pp ▼	#23	[4]
Share of bachelor's in health professions	12%	**8.2%**[2025]	−3.9 pp ▼	12%	+1.1 pp ▲	#47	[4]
Share of bachelor's in business	20%	**21%**[2025]	+1.1 pp ▲	19%	−0.1 pp ▼	#16	[4]
STEM share of master's	12%	**17%**[2025]	+4.4 pp ▲	23%	+6.7 pp ▲	#36	[4]
Share of master's in computer & information sciences	5.1%	**7.7%**[2025]	+2.5 pp ▲	10%	+6.3 pp ▲	#27	[4]
Share of master's in engineering & eng. technology	3.6%	**4.4%**[2025]	+0.8 pp ▲	6.7%	−0.2 pp ▼	#35	[4]
Share of master's in mathematics & statistics	0.8%	**1.6%**[2025]	+0.9 pp ▲	1.3%	+0.3 pp ▲	#10	[4]
Share of master's in biological & biomedical sciences	1.2%	**1.7%**[2025]	+0.5 pp ▲	2.5%	+0.6 pp ▲	#39	[4]
Share of master's in physical sciences	0.3%	**0.6%**[2025]	+0.3 pp ▲	0.8%	−0.1 pp ▼	#31	[4]
Share of master's in health professions	17%	**15%**[2025]	−2.2 pp ▼	15%	+1.7 pp ▲	#21	[4]
Share of master's in business	25%	**25%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	21%	−3.2 pp ▼	#10	[4]
STEM share of research doctorates	46%	**43%**[2025]	−2.5 pp ▼	39%	−2.2 pp ▼	#23	[4]
Share of research doctorates in computer & information sciences	1.6%	**4.0%**[2025]	+2.4 pp ▲	4.2%	+1.4 pp ▲	#19	[4]
Share of research doctorates in engineering & eng. technology	14%	**14%**[2025]	+0.8 pp ▲	14%	−1.0 pp ▼	#20	[4]
Share of research doctorates in mathematics & statistics	3.9%	**3.5%**[2025]	−0.4 pp ▼	2.4%	−0.2 pp ▼	#7	[4]
Share of research doctorates in biological & biomedical sciences	16%	**14%**[2025]	−2.0 pp ▼	10%	−1.1 pp ▼	#12	[4]
Share of research doctorates in physical sciences	10%	**7.0%**[2025]	−3.1 pp ▼	7.1%	−1.1 pp ▼	#32	[4]
Share of research doctorates in health professions	16%	**19%**[2025]	+3.6 pp ▲	12%	+3.5 pp ▲	#11	[4]
Share of research doctorates in business	3.2%	**3.8%**[2025]	+0.6 pp ▲	5.6%	+1.3 pp ▲	#22	[4]
Bachelor's degrees per 100 undergraduates	11.6	**12.1**[2025]	+0.5 ▲	12.3	+1.4 ▲	#33	[4]
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS							
First-time students from outside the U.S.	3.6%[2016]	**2.6%**[2024]	−1.0 pp ▼	3.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#25	[4]
STEM master's degrees earned by international students	386	**556**[2025]	+44% ▲	117K	2.18× ▲	#31	[4]
Share of all U.S. international STEM master's degrees	0.7%	**0.5%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	–	–	#31	[4]

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IOWA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
International share of undergraduate enrollment	3.6%	**2.7%**[2024]	−1.0 pp ▼	3.0%	−0.3 pp ▼	#25	[4]
International share of graduate enrollment	12%	**15%**[2024]	+3.6 pp ▲	17%	+2.8 pp ▲	#23	[4]
International share of all bachelor's	5.1%	**3.5%**[2025]	−1.6 pp ▼	4.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#19	[4]
International share of STEM bachelor's	9.4%	**6.1%**[2025]	−3.3 pp ▼	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#17	[4]
International share of all master's	9.5%	**16%**[2025]	+7.0 pp ▲	22%	+6.2 pp ▲	#24	[4]
International share of STEM master's	38%	**55%**[2025]	+17.2 pp ▲	52%	+9.1 pp ▲	#12	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences master's	44%	**81%**[2025]	+36.2 pp ▲	65%	+10.1 pp ▲	#11	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology master's	41%	**44%**[2025]	+3.4 pp ▲	50%	+0.9 pp ▲	#23	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics master's	30%	**22%**[2025]	−7.9 pp ▼	55%	+6.1 pp ▲	#36	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences master's	19%	**15%**[2025]	−4.2 pp ▼	23%	+6.2 pp ▲	#31	[4]
International share of physical sciences master's	32%[2016]	**23%**[2025]	−9.6 pp ▼	33%	+3.5 pp ▲	#34	[4]
International share of all research doctorates	31%	**30%**[2025]	−0.8 pp ▼	25%	−1.0 pp ▼	#13	[4]
International share of STEM research doctorates	45%	**46%**[2025]	+1.7 pp ▲	43%	−0.5 pp ▼	#14	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences research doctorates	–	**63%**[2025]	–	56%	–	#10	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology research doctorates	60%	**62%**[2025]	+1.6 pp ▲	55%	−1.0 pp ▼	#11	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics research doctorates	41%	**52%**[2025]	+11.0 pp ▲	53%	+2.9 pp ▲	#14	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences research doctorates	31%	**27%**[2025]	−4.5 pp ▼	23%	−4.3 pp ▼	#14	[4]
International share of physical sciences research doctorates	45%	**43%**[2025]	−2.5 pp ▼	38%	−1.1 pp ▼	#14	[4]
Active F-1/M-1 students, all levels	13.3K	**9.02K**[2026]	−32% ▼	1.19M	−0.1% ▼	#31	[20]
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	1.1%	**0.8%**[2026]	−0.4 pp ▼	–	–	#31	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from India	7.7%	**13%**[2026]	+4.8 pp ▲	27%	+11.4 pp ▲	#35	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from China	40%	**10%**[2026]	−30.2 pp ▼	18%	−11.7 pp ▼	#28	[20]
Share from the two largest countries of origin	48%	**23%**[2026]	−25.4 pp ▼	45%	−0.3 pp ▼	#43	[20]

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IOWA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
Countries of citizenship represented	170	**173**[2026]	+1.8% ▲	219	−2.7% ▼	#17	[20]
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students	6.05K	**4.78K**[2026]	−21% ▼	749K	+61% ▲	#28	[20]
Active STEM master's students	1.59K	**1.16K**[2026]	−27% ▼	393K	+90% ▲	#36	[20]
Active STEM doctoral students	1.55K	**1.86K**[2026]	+20% ▲	158K	+61% ▲	#24	[20]
Share of STEM master's students from India	23%	**59%**[2026]	+36.0 pp ▲	58%	−1.8 pp ▼	#24	[20]
U.S. students studying abroad for credit, from the state's institutions	5.95K[2017]	**4.45K**[2024]	−25% ▼	–	–	#25	[1]
Economic contribution of international students, nominal dollars	$410M[2018]	**$267M**[2024]	−35% ▼	$42.9B	+4.6% ▲	#30	[2]
Jobs supported by international students' spending	3.6K[2018]	**1.84K**[2024]	−49% ▼	356K	−22% ▼	#30	[2]
Share of U.S. student and exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.6%	**0.5%**[2024]	−0.2 pp ▼	–	–	#33	[16]
Share of U.S. F-1 student admissions, by destination	0.7%	**0.5%**[2024]	−0.2 pp ▼	–	–	#29	[16]
Share of U.S. J-1 exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.5%	**0.4%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#39	[16]
J-1 exchange visitors starting a program in the state	2.18K	**1.68K**[2025]	−23% ▼	275K	−14% ▼	#38	[18]
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH							
Graduate students in science & engineering	6.42K	**6.62K**[2016]	+3.0% ▲	620K	+0.4% ▲	#26	[9]
S&E graduate students on temporary visas	3.06K	**3.29K**[2016]	+7.5% ▲	241K	+2.3% ▲	#20	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students	48%	**50%**[2016]	+2.1 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#4	[9]
Temporary-visa share of engineering graduate students	59%	**58%**[2016]	−0.6 pp ▼	57%	0.0 pp	#16	[9]
S&E postdoctoral appointees	434	**423**[2016]	−2.5% ▼	45.7K	+1.0% ▲	#25	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs	61%	**63%**[2016]	+2.8 pp ▲	56%	−0.9 pp ▼	#8	[9]
University R&D spending, nominal dollars	$759M	**$1.18B**[2024]	+56% ▲	$118B	+71% ▲	#27	[6]
Share of U.S. university R&D	1.1%	**1.0%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#27	[6]
Federally funded share of university R&D	45%	**47%**[2024]	+2.0 pp ▲	55%	−0.2 pp ▼	#38	[6]
Business-funded share of university R&D	4.8%	**5.4%**[2024]	+0.7 pp ▲	5.4%	−0.4 pp ▼	#16	[6]
State- and locally funded share of university R&D	7.1%	**3.7%**[2024]	−3.4 pp ▼	5.2%	−0.4 pp ▼	#34	[6]
University R&D in mathematics and computer science, nominal dollars	$21.1M	**$36.3M**[2024]	+72% ▲	$5.12B	+97% ▲	#26	[6]

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IOWA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH (CONTINUED)							
University R&D in engineering, nominal dollars	$135M	**$218M[2024]**	+62% ▲	$19.3B	+74% ▲	#24	[6]
University R&D personnel, headcount	12.7K	**13.1K[2024]**	+3.6% ▲	1.09M	+20% ▲	#26	[6]
Federal R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$567M	**$831M[2024]**	+47% ▲	$193B	+53% ▲	#31	[8]
Federal R&D obligations to universities in the state, nominal dollars	$267M	**$383M[2024]**	+44% ▲	$44.4B	+64% ▲	#27	[8]
Defense R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$182M	**$289M[2024]**	+59% ▲	$97.2B	+60% ▲	#29	[8]
Health (HHS/NIH) R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$169M	**$237M[2024]**	+40% ▲	$48.5B	+62% ▲	#30	[8]
NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science grants performed in the state, nominal dollars	$225M	**$280M[2025]**	+24% ▲	$45B	+47% ▲	#32	[19]
Federal R&D contracts performed in the state, nominal dollars	$68.3M	**$24.6M[2026]**	−43.7 ▼	$59.3B	+22,105.9 ▲	#40	[19]
COLLEGE COSTS AND OUTCOMES							
Median earnings 10 years after entering college	$45.9K[2020]	**$47.1K[2022]**	+2.6% ▲	$47.5K	+11% ▲	#32	[15]
Median earnings 1 year after completing	–	**$48.2K[2025]**	–	$47.5K	–	#25	[15]
Median debt of completers, nominal dollars	$21.5K	**$21.3K[2024]**	−1.2% ▼	$17.6K	−4.6% ▼	#4	[15]
STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$69.9K[2025]**	–	$68.2K	–	#14	[15]
Non-STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$46.7K[2025]**	–	$51.9K	–	#40	[15]
Bachelor's graduates: median earnings 5 years out	–	**$65.3K[2025]**	–	$68.1K	–	#35	[15]
STEM master's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$111K[2025]**	–	$91.6K	–	#3	[15]
Six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions	67%	**69%[2024]**	+1.9 pp ▲	65%	+5.3 pp ▲	#9	[4]
Completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions	28%	**44%[2024]**	+15.9 pp ▲	41%	+12.1 pp ▲	#16	[4]
In-state tuition & fees, public 4-year	$10.4K	**$10.9K[2023]**	+4.3% ▲	$9.71K	−14% ▼	#20	[4]
State & local appropriations per FTE, public institutions	$10.3K	**$9.86K[2024]**	−4.4% ▼	$11.4K	+22% ▲	#34	[4]
Net tuition share of tuition plus state and local appropriations, public institutions	49%	**51%[2024]**	+1.5 pp ▲	43%	−5.9 pp ▼	#18	[4]
Average full-time faculty salary (9/10-month)	$99.9K[2016]	**$88.1K[2024]**	−12% ▼	$106K	−4.6% ▼	#36	[4]
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO							

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IOWA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
International graduates on OPT working in the state where they studied	35%	**34%**[2016]	−1.3 pp ▼	44%	−1.8 pp ▼	#27	[21]
OPT retention, bachelor's graduates	44%	**41%**[2016]	−3.4 pp ▼	58%	+0.3 pp ▲	#33	[21]
OPT retention, master's graduates	30%	**26%**[2016]	−3.8 pp ▼	39%	−2.5 pp ▼	#32	[21]
OPT retention, STEM graduates	29%	**25%**[2016]	−4.1 pp ▼	37%	−1.9 pp ▼	#30	[21]
OPT workers employed in the state per OPT graduate of its schools	0.86	**0.89**[2016]	0.0	1.00	0.0	#25	[21]
STEM OPT extensions approved, by state of the school	228	**287**[2016]	+26% ▲	41.2K	+51% ▲	#29	[21]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year after graduating (PSEO)	57%[2016]	**57%**[2019]	0.0 pp	72%	−0.1 pp ▼	#24	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 5 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**48%**[2016]	–	65%	–	#30	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 10 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**51%**[2010]	–	64%	–	#27	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	48%[2016]	**49%**[2019]	+0.4 pp ▲	67%	+1.5 pp ▲	#27	[11]
Master's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**58%**[2016]	–	66%	–	#24	[11]
Doctoral graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**34%**[2016]	–	49%	–	#33	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$47.3K[2016]	**$48.2K**[2019]	+1.8% ▲	$48.1K	+2.3% ▲	#16	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 5 years out (PSEO)	–	**$67.1K**[2016]	–	$67.3K	–	#18	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$62.7K[2016]	**$62.4K**[2019]	−0.5% ▼	$59.3K	+0.1% ▲	#6	[11]
Net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents	−7.6	**−6.4**[2025]	+1.2 ▲	–	–	#47	[12]
Net domestic migration of graduate-degree holders	−1.85K	**−3.48K**[2025]	−1,633.0 ▼	–	–	#45	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved in from another state	2.6%	**1.7%**[2025]	−1.0 pp ▼	–	–	#49	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved out to another state	3.4%	**2.3%**[2025]	−1.1 pp ▼	–	–	#41	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who arrived from abroad in the past year	4.66K	**3.83K**[2025]	−18% ▼	–	–	#32	[12]
First-time students who are in-state residents	61%[2016]	**66%**[2024]	+4.9 pp ▲	–	–	#35	[4]
Net student migration (per 100 resident first-time students)	+35[2016]	**+23**[2024]	−12.1 ▼	–	–	#10	[4]

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IOWA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
Recent high school graduates who go to college out of state	13%[2016]	**15%[2022]**	+1.9 pp ▲	22%	+2.5 pp ▲	#39	[3]
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS							
Certified H-1B positions, by worksite	6.03K	**2.88K[2025]**	−52% ▼	914K	−24% ▼	#31	[17]
Share of U.S. certified H-1B positions	0.5%	**0.3%[2025]**	−0.2 pp ▼	–	–	#31	[17]
STEM share of certified H-1B positions	86%	**53%[2025]**	−33.3 pp ▼	76%	−7.8 pp ▼	#39	[17]
Median offered H-1B wage, nominal dollars, nominal dollars	$65K	**$95K[2025]**	+46% ▲	$119K	+66% ▲	#34	[17]
H-1B positions at H-1B-dependent employers	59%	**18%[2025]**	−41.6 pp ▼	22%	−25.7 pp ▼	#26	[17]
Green-card labor certifications	303	**594[2025]**	+96% ▲	138K	+75% ▲	#30	[17]
Share of PERM certifications for citizens of India	57%	**19%[2024]**	−37.9 pp ▼	47%	−10.6 pp ▼	#40	[17]
PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas	4.4%	**4.7%[2024]**	+0.3 pp ▲	8.7%	+4.9 pp ▲	#43	[17]
PERM workers with a master's or doctorate	51%	**18%[2024]**	−33.2 pp ▼	47%	−4.9 pp ▼	#43	[17]
STEM share of PERM certifications	65%	**48%[2025]**	−17.0 pp ▼	49%	−25.8 pp ▼	#19	[17]
Median offered PERM wage, nominal dollars, nominal dollars	$82K	**$85.5K[2025]**	+4.2% ▲	$100K	+9.9% ▲	#23	[17]
New lawful permanent residents (green cards), by state of residence	5.05K	**5.91K[2024]**	+17% ▲	1.36M	+30% ▲	#32	[16]
Share of U.S. new green-card holders	0.5%	**0.4%[2024]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#32	[16]
People naturalized as U.S. citizens, by state of residence	2.57K	**3.53K[2024]**	+37% ▲	819K	+12% ▲	#32	[16]
Share of U.S. naturalizations	0.4%	**0.4%[2024]**	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#32	[16]
Share of U.S. temporary-worker admissions, by destination	0.2%	**0.3%[2024]**	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#36	[16]
Share of U.S. H-1B worker admissions, by destination	0.3%	**0.2%[2024]**	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#32	[16]
Share of U.S. L-1 intracompany-transferee admissions, by destination	0.3%	**0.3%[2024]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#33	[16]
Share of U.S. O-1 extraordinary-ability worker admissions, by destination	0.1%	**0.1%[2024]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#40	[16]
New H-1B approvals (initial), by employer state	384	**461[2026]**	+20% ▲	127K	+14% ▲	#30	[13]
Continuing H-1B approvals, by employer state	518	**999[2026]**	+93% ▲	268K	+52% ▲	#28	[13]
Share of U.S. new H-1B approvals	0.3%	**0.4%[2026]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#30	[13]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

IOWA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Denial rate, new H-1B petitions	4.5%	**3.2%**[2026]	−1.3 pp ▼	3.4%	−3.0 pp ▼	#33	[13]
New H-1B approvals at colleges and schools (NAICS 61)	45%	**32%**[2026]	−13.2 pp ▼	8.6%	−1.7 pp ▼	#9	[13]
New H-1B approvals in professional, scientific & technical services	26%	**23%**[2026]	−3.0 pp ▼	44%	−12.5 pp ▼	#34	[13]
Five largest employers' share of new H-1B approvals	50%	**35%**[2026]	−15.0 pp ▼	9.1%	−6.7 pp ▼	#24	[13]
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION							
Workers in STEM occupations	79.2K	**104K**[2024]	+31% ▲	13.7M	+51% ▲	#32	[12]
STEM workers as a share of all workers	5.0%	**6.2%**[2024]	+1.2 pp ▲	8.1%	+2.1 pp ▲	#39	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers	12%	**10%**[2024]	−2.1 pp ▼	24%	+1.6 pp ▲	#37	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers with a graduate degree	29%[2016]	**26%**[2024]	−2.9 pp ▼	41%	+2.0 pp ▲	#26	[12]
Noncitizen share of STEM workers	7.7%	**4.7%**[2024]	−3.0 pp ▼	11%	+0.7 pp ▲	#41	[12]
STEM workers born abroad who arrived in the last 10 years	6.4%	**4.8%**[2024]	−1.6 pp ▼	7.5%	+0.3 pp ▲	#25	[12]
Foreign-born share of residents	4.8%	**6.6%**[2025]	+1.8 pp ▲	15%	+1.3 pp ▲	#34	[12]
Foreign-born share of graduate-degree holders, 25+	8.8%	**9.4%**[2025]	+0.7 pp ▲	21%	+2.8 pp ▲	#39	[12]
STEM jobs, employer survey	67.4K	**79.6K**[2025]	+18% ▲	10.4M	+26% ▲	#32	[10]
STEM jobs concentration vs the U.S., location quotient	0.74	**0.77**[2025]	0.0	1.00	0.0	#38	[10]
Mean annual STEM wage, nominal, nominal dollars	$72.2K	**$96K**[2025]	+33% ▲	$120K	+38% ▲	#41	[10]
Median software developer wage, nominal, nominal dollars	$94K[2019]	**$115K**[2025]	+22% ▲	$136K	+26% ▲	#40	[10]
Software developer jobs	9.55K	**9.04K**[2025]	−5.3% ▼	1.69M	+48% ▲	#30	[10]
Mean annual wage, all occupations, nominal, nominal dollars	$41.8K	**$59.8K**[2025]	+43% ▲	$69.8K	+44% ▲	#42	[10]
Patents granted to assignees in the state	965	**1.14K**[2025]	+19% ▲	135K	−0.6% ▼	#25	[22]
Share of U.S.-assignee patents	0.7%	**0.9%**[2025]	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#25	[22]
Share of the state's patents in digital technologies	11%	**8.7%**[2025]	−2.4 pp ▼	43%	+1.6 pp ▲	#47	[22]
Share of the state's patents in life sciences	16%	**9.1%**[2025]	−7.4 pp ▼	17%	+0.4 pp ▲	#44	[22]
Share of the state's patents in semiconductors	0.9%	**0.1%**[2025]	−0.8 pp ▼	2.9%	−1.7 pp ▼	#43	[22]
Women's share of inventors on the state's patents	10%	**15%**[2025]	+4.7 pp ▲	14%	+3.4 pp ▲	#9	[22]

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